Forging Ahead

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31533692.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by Baxter54132

Summary

The war with Horde Prime is over. The Princesses all return home to rebuild their kingdoms and Adora starts her journey to bring magic to all of Etheria.

Catra just wonders where she fits in to all of this. With some help from Adora, some new friends, and some old ones, she's confident she can find her way.

Notes

Huge thank you to Dalblauw for beta reading for me on this. My friend is a talented artist so please check her out at https://dalblauw.carrd.co/ if you'd like!

Currently it seems like this fic will be 11 chapters, but we will see how it goes. Thank you for coming to read this fic.

Happily Ever After

Following the defeat of the Horde the rebellion takes one night to celebrate, and celebrate they do. They party the night away, surrounded with good food and music. Stories of hope and perseverance are shared over raised glasses. While they're partying the future seems bright and optimistic, but once the sun starts peeking over the horizon the reality sinks in that there's more work to be done. Etheria still needs their help. The Princesses rub the sleep out of their eyes, and after many heartfelt goodbyes and a few shed tears, mostly from Perfuma, each Princess returns to their respective Kingdom. They agree to gather in Bright Moon in three weeks to discuss the future direction of the rebellion, but for now will focus on helping their citizens.

Catra doesn't have a Kingdom to call her own, but Adora links their hands together and tugs her towards Bow, Glimmer, and Swift Wind to head to Bright Moon. Melog sticks faithfully to her side as they travel, walking in step and peering around curiously at the new world it's in. Now that the group isn't constantly on alert, Melog has questions about everything around them.

What kind of plant is that?

"That's hemlock."

Can I eat it?

"No!" Catra exclaims a little too loudly, drawing the attention of the rest of their traveling party. Catra's cheeks heat up, she wishes she could trade spots with Melog. It hasn't noticed that Catra's outburst caused their journey home to skid to a stop as gives her a quizzical look, cute head tilt and all. Catra addresses the peanut gallery with a sharp tone, "What?" she demands and motions down with a large sweeping motion. "I was talking to Melog."

Adora merely laughs light-heartedly, her smile washing warmly over Catra. She walks over and leans down to pat Melog gently on the head. She speaks softly, "If Catra says no that means no, okay Melog?" Melog purrs in response, its eyes shutting from happiness. After a moment, Adora stands up and places her hand on Catra's shoulder, giving it an affectionate squeeze. Catra leans into the touch, fighting the urge to purr since she's hyper aware Adora's friends are still watching them. "You're gonna love Bright Moon."

The rest of the journey goes by quickly, and soon Catra stands at the entrance to Bright Moon. It's been many months since she was there, but with how fast things have been moving it feels like she was only away for a moment. The citizens of Bright Moon are gathered around the entrance, and they start cheering when Glimmer leads their rag tag bunch into the city. Catra sticks close to Adora's side as they walk up the road leading to the castle, a little worried that someone will recognize her from the Horde and call her out. Adora waves excitedly at the crowd, giving Catra some time to glance around as they walk.

The city is different from how she remembers it. Many of the large shops are still standing, but here and there a pile of rubble lies where a home once stood. Catra's heart weighs heavy seeing the smiling Bright Moon citizens. These people have suffered so much at the hands at the Horde, yet here they are cheering as if nothing is wrong. Catra's never thought of random citizens as strong, yet they stand before her showing greater strength than she ever has.

"Hey," Adora's concerned voice pulls her attention back to the blonde Princess walking beside her. Adora laces her fingers with Catra's, "Are you okay?"

Old habits die hard and Catra turns her head away on reflex with a bitter retort. "I'm fine." The weight on Catra's heart does lift slightly at Adora's concern and she tightens her grip on Adora's hand so she doesn't pull away.

That was mean. Melog chimes in with its opinion from where it's walking in front of them. It glances over its shoulder with a meaningful stare.

Catra clears her throat. "Sorry Adora, I really am okay though."

Adora, sweet kind Adora, accepts her answer with a small nod and goes back to waving and greeting citizens with her free hand. They're nearly at the castle by now, and Catra is relieved when they finally arrive.

Adora already has a room in the castle, and they give Catra one down the hall. The room is far more spacious than any bedroom in the Horde which Adora proudly points out as they enter. In the center is a giant fluffy mountain of… well Catra isn't exactly sure what it is. "What is that thing and why is it here?" She asks critically, pointing at the aforementioned object with an eyebrow raised.

"That's an Etherian bed." Adora answers, sitting down on what seems to be a massive pile of pillows. "It's a lot at first. I'll ask Glimmer if we can get you a normal bed tomorrow."

Catra throws a few of the pillows into a pile on the floor for Melog and sits down on the 'bed' next to Adora, feeling the sudden urge to lean into her friend. No, friend isn't the right word, they aren't just friends anymore. Catra isn't sure what they are exactly, but as she inhales and gets lost in Adora's fresh, lemony scent, she knows it's more than friends.

Adora lays back on the bed with a satisfied sigh and raises her arm. "C'mere." She motions with her fingers for Catra to lie down with her.

Catra doesn't hesitate in complying and snuggles into Adora's side, inhaling and exhaling deeply as Adora wraps her arm around Catra's shoulders. Adora brings her head down to kiss Catra on the forehead and for a moment they lie there, completely at peace. Kind of at peace anyway, as Catra feels like she's going to

fall through the bed and into an alternative dimension at any moment.

Catra wiggles a little, “Adora, I love you, but this bed is so uncomfortable.”

Adora giggles, though it’s muffled by Catra’s hair. She traces slow circles on Catra’s arm with her index finger and pulls her head back a little so she can actually respond. “I know, but they love these here. Sometimes I try them out again to see if my opinion will change.”

“Etherians are so weird.” Catra rolls her eyes and is rewarded with another giggle.

Adora loosens her grip so they can sit up, “Let me show you my room, I think you’ll like my bed a lot better.”

“Oh?” Catra waggles her eyebrows. “You know just what to say to a girl.” Catra hops up and walks over to the door. She stops in the doorway and glances over her left shoulder, tilting her head and giving Adora a sly wink.

Adora follows, but her expression has gone slack, “What do you mean? I’m telling you the truth, I really do think you’ll like it.” Her eyebrows draw together, confusion clearly written on her face. “It’s a nice bed, like the ones we had in the Horde.”

Catra reaches out to grab Adora’s hand as she approaches, giving her a mischievous grin. She draws the captured hand up and places a gentle kiss on Adora’s knuckles, pleased when even her most oblivious jock blushes bright pink from the contact. “You’re the best Adora.”

The best friend squad, which includes Catra now, throws themselves into helping rebuild Bright Moon. It actually reminds Catra a bit of Horde work, except everyone here asks for help instead of demanding it.

Every morning, Catra gets up, eats breakfast with Adora, Bow, and Glimmer, and then heads into town. They start on the north border and make their way south. The homes in Bright Moon are made of a plaster like material, great to withstand weather and stay cool even in the summer heat.

They go house by house. First, Adora, Bow, Melog, and Catra clear out any rubble on site while Glimmer transports the bags of plaster from storage to the location on site. Then, Catra opens the bags and dumps the powder and water into two molds, one for each side of the house. Bow stirs one side and Catra stirs the other. Then, they let them dry for 45 minutes and work on another house in the meantime.

Adora takes over from here. Transformed as She-Ra, she picks up each half of the home and places them upright, with Catra painting additional plaster onto the edges of the home so they can stick the two halves together. Once both halves are settled, they remove the molds from the outer shell and the house is nearly done. Bow hangs a unique curtain in the door and windows to give the house its own flare, and a happy citizen gets to see their new home.

At the end of each day Catra chows down on delicious castle food and falls unconscious to start things all over again the following day. After a day or two her fluffy ‘bed’ is replaced with a hard cot, which helps her sleep even better. Melog is also overjoyed to find they left it the pillows to curl up on.

Rinse and repeat, Catra sweats day in and out for the next week, rebuilding every destroyed home in Bright Moon. The citizens are extremely grateful, and Catra finds satisfaction in building things for once instead of destroying them. Once the final home is done they celebrate with an extra rowdy dinner. Catra eats and laughs to her hearts content, but gets tired quickly and sneaks out to go to bed. She passes out almost instantly, falling into a deep sleep.

When Catra wakes up the next morning, the first thing she realizes is that she doesn’t have to go labor in the sun today. Her

whole body relaxes. She stretches her arm to scratch Melog behind the ears, "Good morning."

Melog purrs a greeting back and nuzzles her hand. Catra's eyes are still heavy and she draws her arm back after a few pats. She blinks twice and peacefully drifts back to sleep.

The next time she opens her eyes, the sun shining in has moved, signaling that she has most likely slept well beyond when she was supposed to get up. Melog is still sleeping as well and Catra nudges it with her foot as she rises from the cot.

"Melog, I think we overslept."

Once up, Catra stretches out her back, satisfied when her shoulders pop as she draws her arms over her head. Melog stretches besides her, arching its back cutely. *It's probably fine.*

Catra continues stretching, drawing her left arm across her chest and pulling it with her right arm. "I wonder why Adora didn't wake us…" She trails off, realizing the gravity of what she said. "Melog, where's Adora?" Panic rises in her voice as her eyes flicker around the room.

Melog's fur bristles and changes to red. It dashes towards the door, Catra quicky on its heels. They bust into the hallway and quickly cover the distance to Adora's room. The door is open, and much to Catra's disappointment the room is empty.

A patrolling guard is walking down the hallway and Catra yells out and dashes over to her, skidding on the ground to avoid crashing into them. Her hands clasp around the collar of the guard's shirt and pull down firmly. "Where's Adora?!" Catra can feel herself over-reacting, can feel the tension seeping in her voice, but she can't stop herself. What if something happened, what if Adora left her again? She hyperventilates heavily, realizing that the guard is watching her silently, one hand on the hilt of their sword. Catra takes another deep breath in, counts to three, then exhales slowly

and releases her vice grip on the guard's shirt. She's calm, this is fine. "I'm sorry. Do you know where Adora is?"

The guard clears her throat. "I believe She-Ra got called out for an emergency. Queen Glimmer will know more."

Oh, She-Ra duties. Of coooouurse that's what it is. Catra thanks the guard and makes her way towards the throne room, albeit at a calmer pace than before. Melog keeps up with her, its fur returning to standard blue.

Catra decides to play it casual as she enters the throne room, leaning against the wall next to the door and scanning the room to take note of who is present. Glimmer and Bow are sitting side by side facing away from her at the war table, heads close together as they look at a map of Etheria. Their shoulders are within a centimeter of each other and keep brushing intimately.

One guard is standing in the doorway and eyeballs Catra, but she ignores them and decides to make her entrance. "Well, well, well, if it isn't my favorite Sparkles and Arrow Boy."

"Oh, hey Catra! Good to see you!" Bow greets her over his shoulder and motions to the open seats across from him, "Come join us!"

Catra walks around the war table with Melog following close behind. As she circles Glitter mutters, "I better be your only Sparkles."

If she were anyone else, Catra probably wouldn't have heard it. Having cat ears comes in handy this time. "What was that?" she asks while cracking a grin.

Glimmer clears her throat, a light blush splashing across her cheeks. "Uhh… Nothing! What can we help you with?"

Catra pulls out the chair across from Glimmer, wincing when it screeches against the ground. She sits down and Melog curls up

at her feet. She decides to cut straight to the point. “I’m looking for Adora.”

Glimmer stands up as she responds, “Adora was called out this morning for an emergency.” Glimmer moves to the end of the table and points at a small dot by the water as she continues, “The Sea Elf Village is having trouble with some scattered Horde soldiers.” Glimmer clenches her fist. “I wish I could’ve gone.”

Catra’s heart falls at the news, Adora went on a quest without her. Knowing she is safe should make her feel better, but it just causes her chest to tighten uncomfortably.

Glimmer walks back to Bow’s side and sits down with him again, still grumbling under her breath.

“You’ll go next time,” Bow pats Glimmer comfortingly on the back, bringing a small smile to her face.

The comradery of the two people in front of her brings Catra back to reality. They seem to be closer than before, even more so than when they were returning from space. Catra can’t say she has a strong opinion on their relationship, but she wants to be happy for them. Their gazes towards each other are filled with affection, and Catra suddenly feels like a third wheel. She rises from the table with a snarky quip, “Get a room you two.”

Both Glimmer and Bow blush all the way up to their ears, making eye contact with each other for just a moment and then quickly glancing away.

Catra laughs as she walks back around the table, motioning Melog to follow her. “You guys are too funny. I’ll get out of your hair.”

Bow tries to insist she stay and spend time with them, but Catra doesn’t want to be there anymore, now that she knows for sure that Adora is gone for the day. She’s not quite ready to spend so much time with the lovey dovey couple without Adora.

Catra pauses in the doorway for a brief moment, turning back to face her new friends. “Thank you for your help.” She spins and exits without waiting for a response, pivoting to head back towards her room.

She flops down on her bed upon arrival with a loud sigh. Melog nuzzles her side with a quiet grunt. *What’s wrong? It’s not like she’s gone forever.*

Catra laughs at the question and follow up statement. Of course she knows that Adora will be back. It just feels like the Horde all over again, Adora out fighting for what she believes in while Catra lurks in the shadows. She visibly shivers, the irrational side of her is winning out again. She swallows deeply to wash away some of her anxiety. Melog nudges her hand, still waiting for a response.

Catra slides off the bed so she is sitting flat on the ground, her back pressed against the cool metal of the bedframe. She scratches Melog behind the ear. “You’re right, Adora will be back soon. I just need to be… patient.” The last word is hard to say, but admitting that everything will be fine does alleviate some of her pain.

Melog purrs in satisfaction, curling up and nesting its nose into Catra’s side. *What should we do now? It’s still pretty early.*

Catra looks over to the clock hanging on the wall and confirms it’s 1 PM. “Well first let’s raid the kitchen.”

Melog agrees whole-heartedly, and the two set off to find some food.

Open Communication

By the end of the day, Catra is beyond bored. She ate her fill, explored every nook and cranny of the castle, and convinced Sparkles to play a game of Etherian chess with her, which she lost. Even calling her Glimmer properly couldn't get her a rematch. She ends up in the castle's library, perusing and picking out a few books on Etherian history. Since most of her knowledge comes from the Horde, Catra figures she should probably find out the truth for herself.

She takes the books back to her room and digs in. As expected, they are pretty dry, but the information is surprisingly interesting and Catra quickly loses track of time. The quiet sound of wings flapping in the distance snaps her out of her trance. The shadows extending from the window have reached all the way across Catra's room, signaling more time's passed than she's realized. Her ears twitch as the buzzing sound persists, though it would be undetectable to the human ear. Catra leaves her book open face down on her bed and moves to the closest window to peer outside. The flapping sound is slightly louder here, but Catra can't see anything. She sticks her head out the window and cranes her neck to peer around the front of the building, but no luck.

She hopes it's Adora returning home, but the negative part of her brain whispers that it's probably too early for Adora to be back. Despite the pessimism, Catra sets off towards the throne room. She has to know if her hunch is right.

Fortunately, she's spot on this time, and Adora's ever smiling face comes into sight when Catra's halfway down the hallway. Adora has bags starting to appear under her eyes and is covered in a light layer of dirt. She looks tired, but when her eyes meet Catra's her expression brightens, teeth showing in an even wider grin.

Ten minutes ago, Catra wanted to tell her how annoyed she was at being left behind, but all that is washed away in her presence.

“Welcome home.” Catra smiles at her. “I’d give you a kiss, but you look like you stink.”

Adora laughs warmly in response, “Thank you.” She tugs her shirt collar up to her nose and inhales deeply, “Yeah I do kind of reek. I’m gonna go wash up.” Adora pauses as if she’s forgetting something, her face scrunching up cutely.

“What is it?” Catra can’t help but chuckle at how adorable and sincere she looks.

Adora’s face scrunches up even further. “Hold on… Ugh I was just talking to Glimmer how could I forget this so fast… Oh wait!” Her expression brightens, “Glimmer! We’re having dinner with Glimmer and Bow. I agreed for both of us, I hope that’s ok!” Adora gives her pleading puppy dog eyes, the kind she knows Catra can’t say no to.

Catra did want to spend some alone time with Adora, but she supposes eating with the best friend squad is okay too. “Sure, that’s totally fine, I like your friends.” Catra winks.

Adora laughs, “They’re your friends too, you know. Anyway, I’m going to get washed up. I’ll swing by your room when I’m done and we can go to the dinner together.” Adora gives Catra’s shoulder a gentle squeeze as she passes, entering her own room and shutting the door behind her.

Catra returns to her room for now and curls up on her bed to keep reading her book. She’s only about halfway through and wants to be able to tell Adora she actually accomplished something today. Even though it’s just a book, it’s better than nothing.

She gets through about 20 more pages before a gentle knock on her door draws her attention. “You can come in.” She responds, pleased when a fresh and dirt free Adora pushes into the room.

“You must have been really bored to be reading.” Adora teases her lightly and holds out one hand to help Catra to her feet. “Can

I see?”

Catra makes a mental note of her page and after allowing herself to be tugged to her feet passes over the book. “Oh yesssss, without your presence to guide me I was completely lost.” Catra teases back, though her heart sinks remembering the pain she felt when she woke up that morning. There she goes, lying about her feelings again. Isn’t she supposed to be different than this now?

Catra’s left cheek twitches and as she opens her mouth to speak Adora does so as well.

“Actua..”

“Let’s…”

They both fall silent, Adora’s hands coming up to wave in front of her in a silent apology. “You go ahead.” Adora says, her thoughtfulness once again reminding Catra that she’s nowhere near good enough for Adora.

Catra shakes her head lightly, reaching out to grasp Adora’s still raised hands with her own. “No, it’s okay, what were you going to say?”

Adora’s always worn her emotions on her sleeve, and the smile Catra gets as her reward is bright enough to outshine the sun. “Just that it’s time for dinner and we should go.”

“Oh!” Catra pushes her worries aside for now, they can always talk about it later, “Why didn’t you say so sooner? I’m staaaaaarving.”

Me too. Melog chimes from where it lays beside the bed, head laying on its paws dramatically.

Adora of course can’t hear Melog. She turns with a laugh at Catra’s previous comment and releases Catra’s left hand, her right sliding in place to hold as they walk. “Well, we wouldn’t want you to starve, better get you to dinner ASAP.”

Bow and Glimmer are waiting for them, food already sitting in large plates on the table. They've eaten dinner together for the previous week, but today feels a little different. Catra ponders it for a moment and realizes this is the first time in a while they haven't spent the whole day as a group. It feels nice, rejoining friends at the end of a day being apart.

Catra builds a plate for Melog first and places it on the ground next to her. It thanks her and digs in eagerly.

The group starts eating as well and updates each other on what they did that day. Catra suggests Adora starts them off, but Glimmer injects with a mischievous grin that she wants to go first.

She leads with Catra's bitter defeat at Etherian chess, which despite Catra trying to deflect gets told anyway. Adora is supportive as always and says she can practice with Catra for next time.

Catra chuckles as she grabs another biscuit off the center plate. "Considering how bad you were at planning against the Horde, I'm not sure it'll help."

"Well maybe I've gotten better since then." Adora retorts, reaching for a biscuit herself. "We did catch Double Trouble…" She pauses to take a bite out of her biscuit, chew, and swallow. "We could also ask Bow to help us."

"Hey!" Glimmer protests, "No using Bow against me!"

Bow grins widely from being the center of attention. His eyes are locked on Glimmer and he ruffles her hair affectionately, "Now now, you can't keep me all for yourself." He turns back towards Catra. "I'd be happy to help you with chess strategy, just know that nothing we discuss will be kept private." He leans into the table and lowers his voice. "I'm not good at keeping secrets, especially from Glimmer."

"We already know that Bow." Glimmer quips with a friendly smile. The group bursts out in laughter and moves on to the next topic.

“Tell us about the Sea Elf Village.” Glimmer encourages Adora to go next. She seems eager to know what she missed out on.

Adora’s eyes light up as if she’d forgotten her own adventure earlier that day. “Oh! That’s right! The Sea Elf Village was great!! There were at least 10 Horde clones there, but it was no problem for She-ra.” Adora pauses and glances around the room as if searching for something. After twenty seconds her eyes fall on a fruit bowl sitting at the center of the table. The bowl is just out of Adora’s reach, so Catra passes it over wordlessly.

“Thank you.” Adora gives her a toothy grin before turning her attention back to the fruit. She picks up an apple, two oranges, and a pear. “Okay, so imagine these are the Horde soldiers.” She moves the bowl aside to make space and puts the fruit down in a sloppy circle. She returns to the bowl and grabs a bunch of grapes, plucking one off and placing it in the center of her newly created scene. “This one is me.”

“Were the Horde soldiers really 10 times as big as you?” Bow points out skeptically, a grin breaking out on his face.

Adora doesn’t realize he’s joking and shoots him a quizzical look, “Not everything can be to scale.” She huffs and fiddles more with the fruit, “But if you must know, they were at least three times my size. Anyway…” She picks the grape up with her right hand, “this is me, and I was surrounded just like this. It looked like I was doomed, but I used strategy to win!” Adora moves the grape diagonally, tapping an orange and then bouncing to tap each fruit in turn accompanied with a ‘bam!’ sound effect with each motion.

Everything Adora does is endearing, and this is no exception, but it does bring back Catra’s lurking doubts about her own achievements that day. Or really the lack thereof. She watches as Adora bounces her hand around to each fruit again, picking up the pear on the final round and throwing it over her shoulder with a ‘whooosh.’ Catra twists around to watch the fruit fly, pleased when Melog dashes over to smoothly catch it.

Can I eat this? It tilts its head, holding the fruit gently.

Catra nods, "Go ahead, it won't hurt you. Just spit out the pit when you're done."

Melog purrs in thanks and bites down. *It's sweet.*

Catra leaves Melog to enjoy the fruit and turns back to the table where she realizes she's missed part of the conversation. Adora is talking about clean up now and asking Bow if they can build a tracker to try and find the remaining Horde soldiers.

"Maybe?" Is his uncertain answer. "We do know that the Horde soldiers all have the same source code, but with the HQ ship out of commission I'm not sure how we could track them." He stares at the food on his plate for a moment, his eyebrows crunching in. "Just give me a little time, I'll come up with a way!" He raises his fist in determination.

Adora grins back, "Thank you Bow, I just think it'll help get Etheria back to normal." Adora nudges Catra, "How about you? Other than losing at chess and starting a new book, how was your day?"

Catra's eyes flick from Adora to Bow and Glimmer across the table. Three people with goals, dreams, and skills. Bile rises in her throat at her own inferiority. Her fist clenches, claws digging deep into the table and she looks down at her food. "It was fine," she attempts to speak normally but the words are hard to get out, and though Bow and Glimmer don't seem to notice Adora's eyes widen ever so slightly.

They're in public, so Catra takes a deep breath in, and upon exhaling loosens her claws from the table with a light shake of her head. She forces her lips into a weak smile and glances up to make eye contact with Adora. Her shoulders feel heavy, but she shrugs them in what she hopes looks effortless, "Really, it was a quiet day."

“Okay.” Adora responds quietly, not seeming to buy that everything is fine but also not wanting to start a scene. Catra appreciates her for that and is relieved when Adora asks Bow about his day next, effectively changing the topic.

The rest of dinner goes by smoothly, and after thirty minutes they wrap up and excuse themselves for the night. Catra wants to go directly to her room and sleep the rest of the day away, but she only gets a few steps down the hall before she’s stopped by a gentle tug on her right hand.

She turns back, not surprised to see Adora standing there, eyes shining with worry. Adora pulls her gently, walking past her and leading her to Adora’s room. Adora stops in front of it and turns back to face Catra, probably realizing she brought Catra here without her even asking if she wanted to come. “Do you want to come in?”

Catra tries to ease her worries with a dry laugh, “Oh, trying to get me in bed?”

Normally, this would throw Adora off her game, but she’s too focused this time and the distraction is a complete failure. “No, I just want to talk.”

Catra flattens her lips in a thin line, her eyes meeting Adora’s and then flicking down to their joined hands. “Okay.” She reaches down with her free hand to pet Melog. “I’ll meet you back in our room later.”

Melog grunts and walks away, likely excited to curl up and get some shut eye.

Catra allows herself to be guided into the room, shutting the door behind them. They walk over to the bed silently and Adora sits down near her pillow, releasing Catra’s hand and patting next to her for Catra to sit. “Okay, tell me what’s wrong.”

Catra sits down with a sigh, leaning against Adora’s shoulder and appreciating the warmth. “It’s stupid.”

“Catra,” Adora says her name filled with warmth and love. She waits to continue until Catra turns her head to make eye contact. “Your feelings aren’t stupid.” She clears her throat. “That being said, if you don’t want to talk about it that’s fine too. You don’t have to.”

Catra is impressed that her stubborn Adora would say that it’s okay to not share something, she really has grown since their days at the Horde. Catra does want to talk, Adora deserves an honest and open relationship, something Catra hasn’t been able to give her previously.

“This might sound crazy, but I guess I just felt useless today.” Catra starts with the heart of the issue, a huge weight immediately lifting off her chest, “You were out there saving Etheria, which is great!! All I did was oversleep, lose at chess, and read a book.” Adora raises a hand to rub Catra’s back gently as she continues. “If it were once in a while I wouldn’t mind, but to think that everyday this will be my life now, I don’t know…” Catra trails off.

Adora continues to tread slow loops into Catra’s back, gently applying pressure between her shoulders. “You don’t know… what? If you want to live in Bright Moon?” Her voice is calm, but Catra can tell she’s worried.

Catra leans harder into Adora’s touch. “It’s not that, I do want to live here. I want to be here, with you.” Her face flares red as the last words slip from her mouth, Adora’s cheeks tinting equally pink back. “Uh… okay let me see if I can explain this better. Growing up, we were both soldiers, right? You left the Horde and found your own path, but I stayed there until the bitter end.”

“Right, but now you’re here with me.” Adora comments. “Which is great, we love having you.”

Catra nods in agreement, “I’m glad I left, but right now I don’t know what to do with myself. We fixed up the town for a week or so, but what now? All I’ve done my whole life is fight, but now

that the war is over what should I do?" Emotion seeps into her voice, her true fears finally coming to the surface, "What if I'm only meant for destruction." Tears prick at the corner of her eyes, "Like I said, it's stupid.

"No, no no, it's not stupid!" Adora reaches up to wipe a stray tear that Catra hadn't realized had fallen from her cheek. "When I first set out I was also worried about what to do, but by trial and error I found my way." Adora's expression turns thoughtful, "Why don't you come with me tomorrow? Entrapta needs She-ra's help." Adora leans over and places a gentle kiss on Catra's forehead. "We would make an epic team."

Catra smiles and sniffles softly, more appreciative than ever to have Adora. "Sure."

For the Honor of Grayskull!

Catra falls asleep nestled in Adora's arms, tail twined around one of Adora's legs. Honestly, it's the best sleep she's had since Adora had left the Horde all those years ago.

Her sleep comes to an end too soon with Adora nudging her awake just as the first rays of sunlight peek into the room.

Catra grumbles but complies and the pair grab a quick breakfast. They bring food back to Catra's room for Melog. Catra apologizes profusely for leaving it alone last night. Melog forgives her easily, but comments it'll need another one of those mysterious fruits it had at dinner.

What are we doing today? Melog asks as it eats.

"We're going to Dryl," Catra sits down to be with Melog, reaching out to pet its back. "I've been there once before it's…" Catra pauses as she tries to think of a good description. "Rocky."

Adora is standing near the door watching them, and her hand, palm extended towards Catra. "Uh, is Melog coming with us?" Adora asks, her head tilting slightly to the right in confusion.

Catra nods, "Of course it is, why?"

"Well… We are going to fly on Swift Wind." Adora's head tilts even further, and her raised hand comes up to rest on her chin. "Maybe I could make a sling. Melog how tall are you?"

Catra imagines Melog dangling in a sack as they fly and 100 scenarios of it falling to its death flash through her mind instantly.

"Actually, that probably wouldn't be safe," Adora continues talking, and now she's started pacing at the front of the room. "Do you think it could cling to Swift Wind's back? I wonder if that would hurt Swift Wind…"

I could just stay home. Melog is done eating now, its gaze is following Adora as she walks back and forth. *I don't mind, I'd like to explore the town.*

Catra's heart sinks at the thought of leaving Melog behind. They've barely been apart since meeting, and leaving it here feels similar to her waking up alone the previous day. She moves her hand up to pet its head and then addresses Adora, "Melog says it doesn't mind staying back."

"Oh!" Adora stops mid step, "Okay! That would be great!" She kneels to be at eye level with Melog, "If you really don't mind."

Melog purrs and licks her face, which needs no translation.

With that settled, Adora and Catra wish Melog well and head outside to find Swift Wind. He's flying aimlessly around the castle and greets them warmly. Adora gives him some hay and they head to the garden to take off. Adora hops onto Swift Wind's back smoothly and reaches out to help Catra up behind her.

Butterflies flutter in Catra's stomach as she accepts the hand and is pulled into place, swinging her right leg over Swift Wind's body and wrapping her arms tightly around Adora's waist. She actually hasn't ridden on Swift Wind before. She's seen Adora ride around on him numerous times, but hasn't had the opportunity to hop on herself. Adora makes flying look easy, well she makes everything look easy, so Catra's sure they will be fine.

Maybe she's holding on too tightly, because Adora twists her head left to peer at Catra. "Are you okay? You look like you've seen a ghost."

A nervous chuckle escapes Catra's lips. "Yeah, just don't let me fall, okay?"

"Never," Adora promises, her voice confident, "Let's go Swift Wind."

Swift Wind takes to the sky, immediately starting to chat with Adora about some Princess in some city or something like that. Catra honestly isn't paying attention. The wind roars in her ears and she presses her cheek to Adora's back, tightening her grip even further.

A few moments later they reach the clouds and Swift Wind levels out, slowing the flap of his wings to hold them at the same altitude.

The wind doesn't slow down, but at least Catra's stomach no longer feels like it's going to fly out of her gut. She picks up her head, noticing the forest is nearly a blur beneath them. The last time she saw the forest like this was when they'd stolen a cruiser and crashed it in the woods. That feels like forever ago, Catra's changed so much since then, they both have.

"It's beautiful." She murmurs, too quiet to be heard by Adora and Swift Wind. They are still chatting away, and Catra wonders if she should be paying closer attention. She decides it doesn't matter and goes back to observing the nature around them, finally loosening her death grip on Adora's waist. Just a little bit though, she still has a good grip.

The flight only takes about 30 minutes, then the trees fade away and a tall mountain looms before the trio. Crypto Castle is nestled inside the largest peak, and Swift Wind moves to land at the front entrance.

Entrapta is waiting for them next to the front door, a giant machine towering over her to her left. It stands nearly three times her height and has a mounted satellite pointing towards the sky. She waves and shouts hello as Swift Wind touches down. "Good, glad you could make it." Entrapta turns towards her machine and fiddles with a small control panel as they dismount from Swift Wind.

"Hey Entrapta, I brought Catra, I hope that's okay?" Adora reaches into the bag on Swift Wind's back and pulls out an apple

to give him. Catra watches her, eyes flicking over to where Entrapta is still typing away.

“Catra? Oh yeah sure, no problem.” She replies without looking up. “Just give me one second and then I’ll be ready for She-ra.”

“Right.” Adora holds up her hand and curls her fingers as if holding a sword. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

Adora lights up and begins her transformation, starting at her shoes and moving its way up towards her head. Catra watches from start to finish, she’s always loved watching Adora turn into She-ra, always happy to see her own headpiece form on Adora’s head.

The costume change is done in a brief few seconds, then Adora stands as She-ra, a couple feet taller and twice as majestic. No matter how she appears, Catra knows she’s still the same Adora on the inside.

“Okay,” Adora gives her sword a couple warm up swings. “I’m ready, what’re we doing?” Adora steps over to where Entrapta is still fiddling on her device. “Is that going to summon Horde soldiers?” Her voice escalates, “Do you need me to fight?” She peeks over Entrapta’s shoulder to squint at the screen and keyboard. “I’m ready,” she repeats, possibly to make sure Entrapta heard her the first time.

Catra leans against the rock wall, flicking her tail as she watches Entrapta continue to work, amused at Adora’s eagerness. Entrapta’s typing intensifies, Catra’s seen her do this hundreds of times, she’s about to be done. In three, two, one.

Entrapta’s hands lift off the keyboard. “Alright.” She swivels and points at the castle, her finger tilting up to point towards the roof. “It needs to go up there.”

Adora follows her finger, her bravado quickly fading, “Huh? You want me to put it on the roof?”

“You can jump real high, can’t you?” Entrapta dead-pans at Adora, blinking twice.

Adora replies slowly, her confidence wavering, “Well, yeah.” She looks from the roof back to the machine.

“Then it should be no problem!” Entrapta moves out of the way as if it’s settled, making room for Adora to get closer to the machine.

Adora still looks confused, “Is it going to summon Horde soldiers?”

Entrapta replies without pausing, “Nope!”

The two of them fall silent, Entrapta staring at Adora who has bunched her eyebrows up, one hand coming up to scratch the back of her neck. “Uh…”

Catra decides to help her perplexed girlfriend. “What does the machine do, Entrapta?”

“Oh, glad you asked.” Entrapta’s expression lights up from excitement. “It’s a radiofrequency transmitter. It can send radio waves up to 10 miles in any direction, which is 9 miles further than I can send radio waves right now.” Entrapta pauses and scrunches up her face, “Umm... It sends a signal to my robots. They can go further away from the castle now.”

Adora nods slowly, “That makes sense! Okay, I got this.” Adora turns towards the castle. She swings her sword with wide strokes back and forth multiple times, summoning brightly glowing platforms ascending the side of the castle like a staircase.

Adora returns to the machine and squats down to pick it up by the base. She hoists it with ease, She-ra’s strength aiding her. She hugs it to her chest and walks into the castle’s shadow, taking the first jump onto the lowest platform. “This isn’t too bad!” She shouts over to where Entrapta, Swift Wind, and Catra are watching. “Hey Swift Wind! Do you mind spotting me?”

Swift Wind revels at the opportunity and flies over to hover next to Adora as she hops from platform to platform. Her climb is slow but consistent, and Catra is once again impressed with Adora's patience. This method is slow, and the Adora that Catra grew up with surely would have gone for a more aggressive strategy. Now, she's clearly learned that the quickest way isn't always the best and taking a little more time is best if it means you get better results.

Catra does wish she could help in some way, but she doesn't have super strength, and she can't fly. Too bad those aren't things you can learn. At least cats always land on their feet; she thinks dryly.

Meanwhile, Entrapta has scurried over to Adora's lowest manmade platform and is prodding it with her hair, Catra can hear her say, "Iiiinteresting" as she pulls a small drill out of her back pocket and starts attempting to chip off part of it.

Catra wonders if she should tell her the platforms will disappear when Adora turns back to normal; but decides to leave her with the temporary joy.

Adora reaches the castle roof and Swift Wind flies down to let Entrapta know. She hops on to Swift Wind's back and hollers, "Let's go Bird-horse!" while motioning for him to take to the sky. He flies her up to the roof to join Adora, quipping something back that Catra can't quite make out.

Catra watches as Entrapta joins Adora on the roof, directing where she wants the radio wave device to be placed. She also procures nails and small rope out of her pocket, Catra wonders what else she has in there. Once the machine is where Entrapta wants, they tie three ropes around the base and nail the ends into the roof. It looks like a solid way to hold it in place.

The group flies down a few moments later, their mission complete. Adora transforms back to her normal self and Entrapta sighs in disappointment when the glowing platforms dissolve into dust before their eyes. She slides off of Swift Wind with a quiet,

“Thank you Bird-horse,” And moves so Catra can hop on behind Adora. Entrapta looks up at them, balancing on her hair, “Thank you both, now it’s off to do more science!” Entrapta spins and runs into her castle, cackling the whole way.

“Well, that was fun.” Adora comments as they watch the castle doors shut firmly behind the Princess. “Let’s see how Glimmer is doing.” Adora reaches into the ruck sack they brought and pulls out her tablet sized electronic device that Catra can’t remember the name of. She taps on the screen a couple times, clicking to call Glimmer.

The device rings three times, then lights up with Glimmer’s face. Her lips turn up in a large grin when she recognizes Adora on the other end, “Hey!! Are you already done in Dryl? That was quick!”

Adora beams back at her, “Yeah we just finished. We have the afternoon free, is there anywhere that needs help?”

“Uhh…” Glimmer hesitates, “One sec, lemme check.” The background behind Glimmer starts to blur and change as she moves through the castle. “I think someone did call earlier, okay I’m at the war table now.” Glimmer falls silent and Catra can hear her press a few buttons off screen. “Yes! Elderon called us about an hour ago. They asked if you were free, but I let them know that you weren’t available today. It could be a nice surprise if you don’t mind going?”

“Say no more!” Adora pats Swift Wind on the neck with her left hand and flourishes with her right, “to Elderon!”

Glimmer wishes them well and they hang up to set off on the second leg of their journey, Catra once again securing herself to Adora’s back.

Adora fiddles in her ruck sack while they fly, offering Swift Wind an apple and also pulling out a sandwich wrapped in paper. She opens it and offers half to Catra, touching the cat girl’s right hand

so she'll loosen her grip and accept it. "It's okay," Adora assures her with a smile over her shoulder, "I've got you."

Catra feels re-assured and takes the sandwich with her right hand, moving her left hand to Adora's shoulder so she can lean back a little and make room to eat. The sandwich appears to have some jam in the middle, and when Catra bites down it's sweet on her tongue. She quickly devours it, not wanting to spend too long with her loosened grip. Once gone, she licks her fingers clean and re-wraps her arms around Adora. "Thank you, did you make that?"

"I did!" Adora confirms, "Did you like it?"

Catra nods, then realizes Adora won't be able to see her action, "Yes, you're an amazing chef, please teach me your ways."

"Are you sure that's what you want?" Adora laughs loudly, her whole body shaking from the exertion. "You know, I think Glimmer and Bow want to be on their own tonight. I could show you my epic cooking skills firsthand, if you want."

"That *actually* sounds super fun, you better not disappoint." Catra leans her head against Adora's back, smiling from the warmth and ease of their conversation. They fall into a comfortable silence for the remainder of the flight. It takes a few more minutes for them to reach Elderon.

As they reach the perimeter of the city Adora goes on high alert, just in case there's a fight waiting for them. The village appears to be perfectly normal, with citizens walking showing no clear signs of danger.

The mayor of Elderon is standing in the middle of town, directing a few other villagers that are dragging a large piece of wood across the clearing. The wood is at least the length a Horde ship and about half a ship wide and one foot thick.

Catra looks down the stretching field where four walls have been constructed, missing a roof. She instantly realizes why they wanted She-ra's help.

Adora is looking that way as well, and she greets the mayor warmly when they land.

Catra was right, the town wants She-ra's help putting their wooden roof onto their new building. Adora agrees, transforming into She-ra and hoisting the roof with relative ease. She summons a few more floating platforms, and a mere minute later plants the roof on top of its walls.

The Elderon citizens cheer from everywhere around town and rush to gather by the building, their hoots and hollers growing louder by the minute. Adora jumps down to land in front of them, waving and smiling at the crowd.

The mayor invites them into their mess hall for a party, which Swift Wind insists they accept. The group enters and is immediately swarmed by curious villagers. Adora introduces Catra to every party goer, and Catra nods along as she hears outlandish after outlandish stories of Adora's triumphs from them.

The group sneaks out about an hour later, it's time to head home.

The three of them arrive in Brightmoon and split up for the night, Adora dragging Catra to the kitchen for "The unforgettable meal she was promised."

Adora makes Catra cover her eyes while she cooks, the only sounds being the occasional smash from her dropping a plate or cooking utensil. Once she's done, she leads Catra through the castle, still with her eyes shut, guiding her up a long flight of stairs and bringing them to the walkway between the moonstone and the castle.

Catra is finally allowed to open her eyes, which brings her immediate amusement.

She doesn't hesitate to give Adora a hard time. "Epic chef my ass, is this all you know how to make?" Catra leans over to pick up yet another jelly sandwich off a small stack of them.

Adora grabs a sandwich off the plate for herself and retorts, “I’d like to see you do better.”

Catra digs into the sandwich, surprised when it’s a different type of jam than the one she had that afternoon. “I take it back, this is genius. How many flavors of jelly do they have in Etheria?”

“At least one more type,” Adora jokes, finishing off her sandwich and picking up a second. “I’ll make sure to use it next time.”

“Maybe next time I’ll try cooking.” Catra offers, “This is great though, thank you for making it.”

Adora smiles widely at the thanks, her true happiness shining through. “Of course!! Oh, what did you think of today? I know you didn’t get to help that much, but it was fun, right?”

Catra ponders the question for a moment, staring down at her half-eaten sandwiches. “I do appreciate you taking me along.” Catra turns so she can lean her back against the walls lining the walkway. “Uhh… How do I put this…”

Adora watches her patiently, waiting while she works through her thoughts.

Catra takes a deep breath in and exhales, “I think I need to find my own path, separate from She-ra.” She flinches at her own words, “I hope that’s okay?” Catra’s ears flick nervously and she looks down at the ground, waiting for Adora’s reaction. Surely, she’ll be upset at Catra moving to abandon her so close to their recent reunion.

A second ticks by, and then another. Adora is still silent. Catra glances back up, her eyes immediately catching Adora’s. Much to her shock, Adora’s got stars in her eyes, her lips turned up in a wide grin. She apparently was waiting for Catra to focus on her again and immediately throws her arms around Catra’s shoulders, letting out a shout of glee. “I’m so proud of you!!!” Adora smushes her cheek against Catra’s. “I’m sure you will find

something, you deserve to be happy too." She leans back. "I will help you!"

Catra smiles from the overwhelming support and warmth sent her way, "Yeah yeah, of course I'll need your help."

Adora releases Catra from the hug, her expression turning thoughtful. "Where should we start?"

"I've been thinking about it a little actually," Catra admits, "Is there any way I can help out Etheria? I did a lot to trash it, I should probably do my part fixing it now."

"You want to help Etheria, that is amazing. Did I already say how proud I am?" Adora looks like she wants another hug, but after a moment settles for a third sandwich instead.

Catra affirms, "Yes you did already say that."

"Good!" Adora nods firmly, nibble on her sandwich thoughtfully. "I might have an idea. I've got frie… I mean we! Weeeee've got friends all over Etheria." Adora blinks, "Anyway, I'm sure they could have you help with their Kingdoms! You can start here in Brightmoon, I'm sure Glimmer has something you can help with."

Adora steps away from Catra and starts her usual pacing, walking four steps away from Catra. "I can make calls tomorrow and chart out a travel route, this'll be great!" She spins around, tapping her right fist against her palm. Her excitement has settled into a more serious expression, "I want to go with you, but I think you should go alone."

The thought of being away from Adora for what sounds like at least a week long journey causes Catra's heart to fall, but she thinks that Adora's right. She needs to do this on her own. "I agree." Catra pushes off the wall and walks over to Adora to take her hands in her own. "Thank you Adora."

Adora smiles warmly, her positivity infectious, "You got this."

An Unexpected Visitor

Adora shifts into planning mode immediately, dialing someone on her pad before the door even shuts to her room that night. When Catra wakes up the next morning, she's instructed to report to General Juliet following lunch. She spends her free time finishing the history book from the previous day, Melog dozing lazily at her feet. After lunch she heads to the front of the castle.

General Juliet is waiting for her, arms crossed and tapping her foot impatiently. They haven't even spent time together, so Catra wonders how she's already so irritated. Juliet huffs at the sight of Catra. "You're late." She scolds, eyes intense as if she can see straight into Catra's soul.

Catra's gut reaction is to be defensive, her blood starting to boil beneath her skin. "Uhhhhm…" She crosses her arms and raises her left eyebrow, "I was told to come after lunch, so here I am." Catra narrows her eyes, mirroring Juliet's body language to a tee.

Juliet purses her lips as they stare at each other silently. For a tense minute neither give on their position; Catra's certainly not about to concede. Juliet holds her gaze for a moment longer before finally looking away. She inhales and exhales with a deep sigh. "Okay… I guess it doesn't matter. Let's get going." Juliet spins on her heel and walks quickly into the castle. "Follow me."

Still somewhat annoyed, Catra trails after her, her tail swishing back and forth as she follows. "Aren't you going to tell me what we're doing?" She asks as they move into the throne room.

"Guard duty." Juliet replies curtly, "Actually let's stop here for a moment." Juliet comes to a halt at the war table. "Please take a seat." She motions for Catra to sit and starts pressing a few buttons on the side of the table.

A map of Etheria pops up, then flickers and changes to a 3-d blueprint of what Catra assumes is Brightmoon castle.

Juliet points towards a large room near the front of the castle. "This is where we are now, and we started here." Juliet moves her finger to the entrance and continues to point at spots as she speaks. "At all times, we have 6 guards on duty. Two are posted at the front entrance, with one at each additional entry point into the castle. Our main responsibilities are to keep unwelcome visitors from entering the castle, and on occasion keep prisoners from leaving." Juliet presses another button to show a schematic of the town. "We also patrol the town and mitigate disputes between civilians."

Catra stays silent and listens, quickly realizing what Adora signed her up for. Juliet had summed it up with her first sentence, though she was missing a word. *Boring* guard duty.

Juliet clicks back to the blueprint of the castle, "We are going to join another prospect at the garden entrance. Do you have any questions before we go?"

Catra considers the question, her eyes still locked on the map. She finds it amusing that three years ago she would've killed to get her hands on this information, now it's readily available and barely holding her interest.

She realizes she's leaving Juliet waiting, the taller woman once again tapping her foot and staring at her expectantly. Catra clears her throat, her cheeks heating up in embarrassment, "Sorry, no questions."

"Perfect, let's keep moving, we've kept her waiting long enough." Juliet turns the war table off with a few button presses and directs for Catra to follow her.

Catra rises and trails after Juliet down the hallway on their left. As they near the garden, Catra squints and peers around Juliet to try and get a glimpse of the other prospect. She wonders if it's one of Adora's friends, maybe the spunky ice one.

She can't get a good look, but after a few more steps the two of them enter the garden.

Catra turns to greet her fellow trainee, "Hell…" The word dies in her throat as a flash of red and white enters her vision.

Catra barely comprehends what's happening before she's crushed in large, familiar arms. The embrace is warm, and though Catra's internal train of thought is still doing gymnastics, it's not unwelcome.

"Catra!!! Ohhhhh my, it's so good to see you." Catra's hoisted off the ground by her shoulders, pincers squeezing her tightly. "Oh, I'm so excited. This is great!!"

Catra's lips turn up in a small smile, "Hey Scorpia." Her arms are still trapped at her sides, so she's unable to hug Scorpia back. "How's it going?"

Scorpia finally places her down with a nervous laugh, "Good! Aha, sorry if I went too far. I know you aren't the biggest fan of hugs." She raises one hand to scratch the back of her neck, the awkwardness between them tangible. "I'm good anyway, did I already say that? How are you?"

Catra's heart falls at hearing the apology come from Scorpia's lips. It's true that she's never responded positively to Scorpia's over enthusiastic physical contact, but she knows her reactions to Scorpia back then were over-reactions to say the least. "No, it's uh.. it's fine. The hugs are fine." Catra's pitch rises on the final words and then comes back down. "I'm okay I guess, It-it's good to see you too." Catra winces at her own voice betraying her emotions.

Scorpia's pincers come up to her own chin, eye's sparkling. She seems not to have noticed Catra's nervousness. "OOoooooh. I've missed you Wildcat. Can I have another hug?"

Juliet clears her throat, posture stiff. "How about later." She gives them both a stern look. "Was there any activity at this entrance?"

“No Ma’am!” Scorpia straightens her back and salutes with her right claw. “No one has come in or out since your departure.”

“Good.” Juliet replies. “You can relax.” She waits for Scorpia to drop her arm before continuing, “it seems no introductions are needed, so I’ll cut right to the chase. As I described earlier, one part of the job is guarding the entrances to the castle. If we determine your abilities are sufficient and you desire to join us, this is the main job you will be doing. Once you have more experience, you’ll start venturing into town and even leaving Brightmoon on missions as required.”

“Ooh, the dastardly duo back at it again, this is so exciting!” Scorpia says, energy clear in her voice.

Catra notices a dark expression setting in on Juliet’s face at being interrupted and remains silent. Her eyes flick to Scorpia and she tries to send a silent warning to not say anything else, flicking her tail against Scorpia’s wrist and then pointing it towards Juliet. The taller ex-soldier glances down at the touch and follows where she pointed, apologizing sheepishly when she realizes what she’s done.

Juliet’s lips flatten into a thin line. “Ignoring that outburst, I’ll leave the two of you here for the next hour or so while I check on the other entrances. It should be quiet, but if you get into trouble use your pad to call for me.”

Catra smirks, “I’m sure we can handle it.” She flashes her nails at the general, “We’ve been in a few fights.”

Juliet gives them unamused frown. “*Call me* if there’s trouble.”

Catra’s grin droops into a light grimace, “Yes Ma’am.”

“Good,” Juliet nods at them both. “If you want to proceed, after this we’ll do a combat test and go from there.”

After confirming they’re all set, Juliet sets off back into the building, leaving Catra alone with Scorpia.

Catra shifts to stand to the right of the entrance, with Scorpia already standing at the left. Her eyes are locked on her hands, which she twines together nervously.

The last time she was alone with Scorpia was after she'd been given the broken recording from Emily, when Scorpia called her a bad friend. The two had spoken briefly after the defeat of Horde Prime, but Catra had avoided her during the following party, it was cowardly she'll admit it.

Shame for her previous actions causes her shoulders to slouch, ears laying back on her head. She needs to make things up to Scorpia, no better time to start than now.

Catra finally glances up, her embarrassment getting worse when she realizes that Scorpia is kindly looking away, staring into the garden.

Catra opens her mouth to speak, then closes it again. Where should she start? How can she even begin to apologize for her negligent and abusive behavior? She inhales deeply from her mouth and after a moment exhales through her nose. She can do this. "Uh… Scorpia?"

Not an amazing start, but it does get her ex-friend's attention. She turns as if startled. "Yes? I mean… yes, what's up?" Scorpia twines her claws together in front of her.

Despite the initial warm welcome, Scorpia's words give away her nervousness. She's probably also thinking about their last fight. Catra holds eye contact for a moment before glancing away. "I'm sorry." She speaks too quickly, the words falling out of her mouth. "I'm sorry for how I treated you in the Horde, for not being a good friend. I'm learning, and I'm trying to be better."

Scorpia barely hesitates before responding. "Of course I forgive you." Scorpia breaks her position to finally claim her second hug, this time only embracing Catra for about ten seconds. She releases her with a smile and returns to her spot by the door. "I'll

hold you to that though, I've also learned a bit more about friendship."

Catra's pleased to hear that, she knows Scorpia's spent a lot of time with the Princess alliance. "You'll have to teach me what you've learned." Catra jokes weakly, "I meant what I said, it really is good to see you."

"Right back at you Wildcat." Scorpia smiles warmly. "I'm actually really surprised to see you here."

If Catra's being honest, she's surprised either of them are there. Two high ranking and active Horde Force Captains settling down to stand in one place for 8 hours a day. It feels weird. "I'm trying it out, for Adora" she admits. "What about you, is this really the life that you want?"

Scorpia merely shrugs. "I don't know. I love being a Princess. Oh yeah! I'm a Princess now. Anyway, I'm not really sure what I want to do. Glimmer mentioned they were looking for a few extra helping hands, and you know how much I like to help." Much to Catra's surprise, a light blush dusts Scorpia's cheeks, "Perfuma would be furious to see me being the muscle again, but maybe this is where I'm meant to be."

Where she's meant to be… it doesn't escape Catra that they're looking for the same thing.

Her protective instincts kick in, "Well don't settle." She turns away grumbling, "You can do better than this." Her arms cross in front of her chest, her ears twitching when she realizes the insinuation of what she just said. "Well, maybe better is the wrong word." Catra hesitates. "This just isn't what I've pictured for you."

"I know what you mean." Scorpia spares her further explanation. "I honestly need to think about it more." Scorpia breaks her station for a second time to walk over to Catra, one scorpion pincer rising to land on Catra's shoulder. "I appreciate the concern, thank you." The two share a smile before Scorpia turns

to step back in place. “I think you can probably find something else too, something with more adventure.”

Catra sighs, “Yeah, I don’t think this is for me.” She leans against the castle wall. “Tomorrow I’m setting off on my Adora-designed road trip, so we’ll see how that goes.”

This peaks Scorpia’s interest, “Oh? That actually sounds super fun, where are you going? I’m assuming Adora’s going with you, that’ll be nice.” If they were standing next to each other, Catra imagines Scorpia would have elbowed her gently in the side.

She shrugs, “Honestly, not sure yet. Adora is still working out the details.” Catra stretches her arms over her head with a loud yawn. She continues speaking once she’s done, “I’m actually going alone though.” Catra pauses as Scorpia shoots her a worried look, “I’ll be fine.” She hurriedly adds.

Scorpia accepts her words easily, the same way she always did back in the Horde. “Don’t hesitate to call me if you need anything.”

“I won’t.” Catra promises.

The two fall into a relaxed conversation, Scorpia telling her the story of what she’s been up to since the defeat of Horde Prime. An hour goes by before they realize it and Julia returns. She debriefs them and asks if either would like to proceed to the exam.

Catra passes; this is definitely not for her. She wants more adventure and excitement. Scorpia hesitates and asks if she can spend some time thinking it through, to which Juliet agrees.

Catra wants to tell her to just reject Juliet outright, but she manages to hold her tongue this time. They wrap up, and Juliet takes them back to the entrance of the castle.

Catra is of course staying on the grounds and Scorpia lets her know she’s staying at a small tavern in the city. Juliet leaves them

at the entrance with a brief and still somewhat annoyed goodbye, and Catra's original nervousness returns at their impending parting.

Scorpia seems uneasy as well and lingers on the landing in front of the stairs. "I guess that's my cue." She laughs lightly. "I'll see you around Wildcat."

"Yeah…" Catra swallows the lump forming in her throat. "See you."

Catra watches as Scorpia gives her a final nod and turns to walk down the stairs leading away from the castle.

As she walks away, a feeling of dread settles in Catra's stomach. She's not sure why, but she's not quite ready to let Scorpia go. "Hey, Scorpia." The words come out barely above a whisper, if Scorpia doesn't hear her then it wasn't meant to be, Catra's holding her up for almost nothing at this point.

Scorpia's tail twitches as she stops mid step and twists her neck to glance back. "What's wrong?"

Catra's heart lifts at her concern. "Uh.. nothing. Just let me know what you decide on, okay? With what you're going to do next."

Scorpia beams, her smile brighter than the sun, "Of course!"

Salineas

Chapter Notes

This chapter got really long. I am sorry but also not sorry.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra doesn't receive any more details other than to get up at sunrise in order to receive her itinerary and set off on her journey. She sneaks into Adora's room that night, pleased when Adora is still awake. Adora smiles warmly and welcomes her to curl up with her under the covers. Melog curls up in a ball to sleep peacefully on the ground next to them.

Adora nudges Catra awake early the next morning and the three of them head to the kitchen to pack some food. Adora shoves at least a dozen fruits and vegetables into her ruck sack, making Catra promise that she'll eat a minimum of two or three per day.

Once Adora's satisfied, they head to the castle entrance. Catra's still rubbing the sleep from her eyes, but Adora's wide awake, going through the ruck sack again to make sure she hasn't forgotten anything. Once they arrive, they pause on the landing in front of the steps for goodbyes. Adora kneels down to pet Melog on the head, her expression still serious. "Take care of her," she requests.

Melog purrs, *Of course.*

Adora can't hear the response, but the cute sound pushes a small smile onto her face as she rises to address Catra. Adora pulls out a large rolled scroll, one Catra hasn't seen before. She realizes that it's a map as Adora rolls it open with both hands.

"Okay, I've confirmed some stops for you and marked them in order." Adora holds out the map towards Catra, "Can you hold it open for me please?" She asks with a sheepish grin.

Catra complies and takes the map from Adora, their fingers brushing as she clasps her hands around each end and stretches her arms so it's taut. The map has a few dark circles drawn around cities, each with a number etched next to them. Catra identifies five marks, and it's easy to identify the projected travel route based off them.

Adora points at the city marked #1 with her now free hands. "You'll start at Salineas with Mermista," Adora points at each location as she continues to list them, "then Plumeria with Perfuma, Kingdom of Snows with Frosta, Dryl with Entrapta and Hordak, and then finally Erlandia before you return home. I let them know the general time frame you'd arrive. I planned about a day for each Kingdom, but if you want to spend a little extra time somewhere don't worry about it. Everyone is flexible."

Catra's impressed with how much work Adora did in just a day, though her heart sinks a little as she realizes she won't see her for at least a week. Also… didn't Adora leave something out from that explanation? "Uhh, who am I meeting in Erlandia?" Catra arches one eyebrow, it's unusual for Adora to forget a detail like that.

Adora blinks once, her grin getting bigger and a bead of sweat appearing on her forehead. "Ah, hahaha. Oh yeah! It's – it's a surprise!" Adora steps back so Catra can roll the map up. "You'll see when you get there, you'll like it, I promise!"

Catra collapses the map and stuffs it into her ruck sack, shooting her girlfriend a skeptical look. "Ooookkkayyy." Normally Catra would press further, but Adora put in so much effort for her, she can wait a couple days for the surprise. It'll be hard but somehow she'll manage.

With the map and food settled, it's time to go. Catra's not sure she's ready, anxiety pooling in her stomach. Weirdly enough, this time she's the one leaving. It doesn't feel any better to be on this side. She needs to be brave; this is her journey and this is the first step. She swallows deeply, pushing a forced smile onto her face. "Be safe Adora."

Adora places a hand onto her shoulder and squeezes gently, warmth flowing from her fingers and instantly soothing Catra's nerves. "Shouldn't I be the one saying that?" She jokes with a lopsided grin.

Catra's smile grows, genuine this time, "Nah, I'll be fine." Catra raises one hand to cradle Adora's chin, leaning in to catch her lips in a quick kiss. She holds for a moment and then backs away, tilting her head so their foreheads touch. "Bye idiot."

"Bye." Adora's voice comes out barely over a whisper, and a heartbeat later she steps back and out of Catra's arms. Catra immediately misses the warmth; but they've stood there for too long already.

Catra slides onto Melog's back and with a quiet command the two take off into the forest. She's careful to not look back, determined not to show weakness like she did with Scorpia the day prior.

Salineas is a few hours ride, and Catra would be lying if she said she isn't nervous. The last time she was in Salineas was when the Horde captured it just before Horde Prime's arrival. She's barely spoken with Mermista since then and hardly feels like the bad blood between them will just evaporate into thin air. She shakes her head to clear her thoughts. Regardless of the past, now it's the future, all she can do is try to make up for her previous actions. Adora set this up for her, and she's going to try her best!

Catra zones out for the rest of the journey, and before she knows it they're standing at the entrance to Salineas. She slips off Melog's back, reaching into her ruck sack to grab two pieces of fruit. She makes sure one is a pear, which she offers to Melog. It chows down happily and Catra eats as well. Only one more to meet her fruit quota for the day, she thinks to herself.

Once done, they head into town. Salineas looks mostly cleaned up, villagers bustling in a small flea market near the entrance and to and from docks that surround the Kingdom. Everything appears to be peaceful, which alleviates some of the guilt Catra felt on her

way here, the city is certainly doing better than the shambles she left them in.

Catra avoids the crowds and locates the staircase leading to the town's castle, pleased to find it without drawing unwanted attention to herself. She climbs steadily, noting that the stairs are clear except for someone resting near the top. His posture is defeated and hunched, elbows resting on legs with his head in his hands.

Catra vaguely recognizes him as the annoying singer that always is hanging around with Mermista. As she gets closer, she can hear muffled sniffles with the occasional sob escaping from his hands. Oh boy, this will be interesting. What is his name again? She remembers one hundred of his bad jokes, but his name escapes her. Great going Catra.

She stops on the stairs in front of him, her shadow casting over his shrunk form. Melog was following her up to this point, and now steps up to join her on the step. It nuzzles against the back of the gloomy man's hands. *Hello.* It purrs.

The man peeks through his fingers, revealing bloodshot eyes. "Why hello there," he reaches out with one hand to scratch Melog behind the ears, the smallest grin pushing onto his face, "it's been a while my friend."

"Hey," Catra interrupts, her short patience flaring at him for not even noticing her. "Sorry to interrupt your brooding or whatever, but can we get by? We're here to see the Princess."

Catra's annoyance grows even further as the sailor stands up with a hasty apology, wiping his hands on his pants. "Oh yes!! Mermista is expecting you! Oh, Mermista…" He turns to glance at the top of the steps, and when he turns back his expression has returned to one of extreme depression. "What have I done?"

At this point, Catra's about ready to push past him and go see Mermista herself. Her past self from the Horde certainly would.

She takes one step, then stops with a small flick of her tail. She decided to better herself and tolerating Adora's friends is a part of that reform. She lowers her foot so she's standing on only one step again. "What happened?" She tries to sound patient, the way Adora always does when she's worried, hoping her usual sass isn't seeping into the question.

"Oh… the usual." His voice is sullen as he responds. "I burned down the SS-Sea Hawk the 8th." He turns to one side, his eyes gleaming, "it was my best boat burning to date!"

Sea Hawk… Sea Hawk. Is that his name? Catra vaguely remembers hearing the word once or twice before, and this guy was always jumping around during those times. She's not confident enough to test it right now, but takes a mental note to pay attention to those addressing him.

While she was pondering his name, Sea Hawk has continued to ramble on about his boat fire, going from excited, to passionate, to angry, then back to sad, all in the span of 30 seconds.

Sea Hawk motions dramatically towards the castle. "You should go without me. Mermista doesn't want to see me right now, it's just ahead at the top of the stairs."

Catra is honestly fine with that, this moody sailor has reached the end of her patience. She steps to the side so she can pass him, but only makes it two steps away before he once again calls out to her.

"Wait!" He pauses, one hand extended towards Catra, "I changed my mind, let me take you. Maybe if I show you the way she'll forgive me."

Catra's not so sure, but she holds her tongue. She doesn't remember the Princess of Salineas being the most forgiving of individuals, if anything she's the opposite. She really doesn't care though, bringing him along will probably be entertaining. "It's your funeral," she jokes, but steps to the side so he can pass.

“Indeed,” Sea Hawk responds with a surprisingly serious tone. He starts climbing the steps without saying anything further. Catra gives Melog a look as they follow.

I like him.

Melog always sees the best in people, something Catra is envious of. She reaches over to pat its head, wordlessly acknowledging its comment.

Sea Hawk is already nearly at the top of the steps and it only takes about a minute for him to reach the top. A tall guard stands at the entrance, speared weapon in hand. As Sea Hawk approaches the entrance, the guard swings down the spear to cut off his path.

Maybe letting him come along wasn’t the best idea after all. Catra hangs back and watches as Sea Hawk leans casually against the weapon and engages in small talk with the guard, assuring her that he is in fact welcome in the castle and isn’t currently banned.

As they continue to chat, he motions over his shoulder. “I brought Catra by the way. You know, the person that Princess Mermista is waiting for.”

That seems to do the trick as the guard finally relents and allows them into the castle. The guard does let Sea Hawk know that she’ll be watching him, to which he responds with a wink.

Once inside, it’s just a short walk to reach the throne room. Well, Catra’s not sure if it’s called that, but it looks very similar to the throne room in Brightmoon. The major difference is the color, the walls are sea-green blue instead of pink.

Mermista is lounging on her throne, a quart of double chocolate ice cream in one hand and a large spoon in the other. She doesn’t seem to notice Catra at first, her eyes locking onto Sea Hawk. “UGHHH. Sea Hawk, why did you come back?” Mermista flicks some ice cream towards him using her spoon, her frown

deepening when he sidesteps to dodge it. “I don’t want you here,” she grumbles.

Sea Hawk dances towards her with a gracious spin. “I know that you’re mad, my love. I am simply delivering our visitor to you.” Sea Hawk reaches into his back pocket and pulls out a single red rose. “By the way, I found this for you while I was out.”

Catra wonders when he had time to pick that up, but that’s a question for another time. At least his name is confirmed now.

Mermista rolls her eyes with an additional groan but accepts the flower. “This isn’t enough to win me back…” She raises the flower to her nose and inhales deeply. “…but it’s a good start, I guess.” She turns to her guard and requests a vase. The guard exits the throne room, leaving the four of them alone for the moment. Mermista finally shifts her attention towards Catra. “You made good time.”

Catra leans down to pat Melog on the head affectionately, “I got a lift from the best, it can run just as fast as any horse.”

Mermista smiles when Melog purrs in response, its head pushing into Catra’s touch. “Cute.”

The guard returns with a slim foot tall vase in hand. She holds the vase out towards Mermista and with a quick thank you Mermista deposits the rose into its new home.

“Hopefully it’ll live longer than MOST of the things you’ve interacted with.” Mermista squints, her irk once again directed towards Sea Hawk.

Sea Hawk leans against one of the pillars lining the throne room, “Plants are much harder to kill.” He raises one hand to runs his fingers through his hair. In Catra’s opinion, his hair looked messy before and still does, but after a moment he seems satisfied and shoots Mermista a finger gun with a sly wink. “I am as well.”

“Ughh, I hate you so much.” Mermista uses her hands against the arms of the throne to stand up, eyes rolling as she does so. Catra watches in amusement as Mermista stomps past him, heading towards the entrance of the room. She motions for Catra to follow and says, “Let’s go.”

Sea Hawk is either not able to read the room or is being willfully ignorant because he chimes in, “Can I come?”

Mermista freezes mid step, spinning on her heels with fists clenched and eyes narrowed. She opens her mouth, presumably to give Sea Hawk a piece of her mind, but pauses when she sees Catra standing there. Catra assumes Mermista forgot she was in the room for a moment, but maybe seeing her reminded Mermista who her true enemies are. Or who they were at least.

Either way, Mermista’s anger seems to temporarily subside. “Catra, what do you think? If he comes there’s a 50% chance something will burn down.” Mermista crosses her arms. “I’ll leave it up to you.”

Catra is surprised at being asked her opinion. It sends a warm and unexpected feeling through her whole body. Mermista should hate her, but she’s including her in their conversation. Truth be told, she still doesn’t really care if Sea Hawk comes or not. He seems entertaining and doesn’t have as much of a grudge against her, but also takes up most of Mermista’s attention. Those are actually all good things. Catra can’t think of a single downside.

“I don’t mind either way,” she comments, “but if he stays here, doesn’t that mean there’s a 50% chance he’ll burn down the castle?” She smiles mischievously, she can’t miss the chance to stir the pot a little.

Mermista grimaces, probably imagining her castle as a pile of ash. “Fair point.” She turns to address the subject of their conversation, still leaning against the pillar and fixing his hair again. “Alright Sea Hawk, you can come, but NO fires!”

“Pshh, you know I can’t make any promises.” Sea Hawk pushes off the pillar with a sly wink, his expression quickly turning into a wince when Mermista shoots him a death glare. “Alright, alright. No fires.”

Catra thinks about making another joke but considering how Mermista looks about ready to throw someone off the roof, she decides to stay quiet.

The conversation reaches its natural ending and finally they’re ready to leave. Mermista leads the way out of the throne room, Catra following behind her with Melog by her side. Sea Hawk stays a few paces behind them, probably wanting to be out of throwing range in case Mermista sees something small and sharp while they walk.

As they clear the castle entrance and return down the stairs she had come in on, Catra realizes she has no clue where they’re going. Adora had instructed her to check in with Mermista, but hadn’t given even a clue as to what she’d planned. Catra walks a little quicker so she’s side by side with Mermista. “So… what’re we doing today?”

Mermista turns her head to glance at her as they walk, her left eyebrow curling up from the question. She seems surprised that Catra doesn’t know. “We’re going sailing.”

The answer takes Catra by surprise, “Sailing?” What could Adora think she can gain from going sailing? Cats aren’t exactly creatures of the water.

Mermista is looking forward again as they continue to walk. She shrugs, “Adora asked us to show you something we’re passionate about. It’s kind of fun, I guess…” Mermista trails off as she turns suddenly, leading them through a narrow alley. At the end, it opens up to a vast beach with a dock on the nearest end.

Sea Hawk takes this moment to chime in. “I love sailing!!” He chirps from behind them. “To be on the sea is to be free!”

Catra's not sure how this will really help her find her place in Etheria, but it is nice to get to know Adora's friends. They've been extremely friendly so far, even Mermista who by all means should despise her. It's a good feeling, to be welcomed in so warmly.

Mermista leads them down the beach to the dock where a small boat is tied down. "I picked this one so even if something does happen…" she gives Sea Hawk a pointed look, "…it won't be a big loss."

The boat is about 15 feet long with a tall mast standing in the center, the sail currently furled. Catra's seen many of these boats fighting the resistance and knows they can go quite fast.

Sea Hawk leaps aboard, greeting the ship with a few sung words and short dance. Catra ignores him, noticing that Melog didn't follow her up on the dock. She turns, finding it sitting at the base of the dock, tail curled around its paws.

I don't do water. It states as if it's a matter of fact.

"I don't blame you buddy." Catra turns back to the boat thoughtfully, her tail flicking back and forth as she thinks. "I guess you can just wait here for us?" She calls out to Mermista who is also aboard the ship now, "Is that fine?"

Mermista shrugs, "Sure that is fine. No one is using this dock but us." Mermista pauses. "Wait, this is just like Mer-Mysteries, the Boat That Drifted to Sea. In that book, Fernando stayed behind, and later he was found DEAD." Mermista places one hand on her chin and leans towards Melog. "What if the same thing happens here?!? That would be… awful!"

Catra's not sure how to respond, she glances at Melog and it's just as confused.

I won't die. It assures her.

Catra looks to Sea Hawk for help, but he's busy adjusting the ropes and isn't paying them any attention. She turns back to

Mermista. “Uhhhhh, I think Melog will be okay. There shouldn’t be any danger, and worst case Melog can handle itself. It’s an alien and can use magic.”

“That’s what they always say…” Mermista strokes her chin, “but fine, just stay here the whole time, and don’t go into the light.” She moves her hand to point her index finger directly at Melog. “I mean it.”

With that decided, Catra boards the ship. Sea Hawk finally takes notice of them and excitingly grabs the rope attached to the dock, pulling it up so they can push away.

Catra stumbles when the boat rocks away from the dock, it lurches more than the steel Horde ships she’s used to. She sits down to steady herself, happy when the boat rocks a little more gently as they move away from the shore.

As she sits, Mermista and Sea Hawk leap into action. A steering wheel stands just in front of the mast, and they take turns holding the steering wheel and also adjusting the ropes on the sail. Catra’s surprised at the minimal communication, just some short shouts and arm motions, but the sail drops and soon they are clicking along at a consistent speed. Catra admits internally that she’s pretty impressed, the rig onboard looks complicated but they made it look simple.

With the sail secured, Sea Hawk and Mermista join her near the front. Sea Hawk sits down near her and crosses his legs. “Are you alright?” He places one hand on her shoulder, causing Catra to flinch. She knows his intentions are well intended, but physical contact from people who aren’t Adora still startles her. He hastily withdraws his hand upon noticing her reaction, “I’m sorry.”

Has anyone ever apologized for touching her without permission? Catra can’t think of a single moment prior to now. His response is touching. “It’s ok, and yeah I’m fine, it’s just a little rougher than I was expecting.”

Sea Hawk leans back against his hands, head tilted towards the cloud filled sky. “Small boats like this usually rock more, and the bigger the boat gets the less you’ll feel it.”

“I was spoiled by the Horde ships I guess.” Catra jokes.

“You could hardly tell you were on the ocean aboard one of those things.” Mermista agrees, sitting down as well to join them. “I just realized we didn’t even have you help with the sails, even though that’s why you’re here.”

Catra honestly doesn’t mind, “It’s fine, watching you guys sail is interesting enough, I would probably mess up anyway.” Catra glances out at the ocean as it zips past them. “It really is beautiful out here.” Catra rises shakily to her feet and after a moment stabilizes and wobbles over to the boat wall so she can lean against it.

That reminds her, something Mermista said earlier piqued her interest. “Hey Mermista, earlier you mentioned Mer-Mysteries. Is that a book series?”

Mermista’s reaction to Catra’s question is far more extreme than she expected. Her jaw slacks, eyes widening in shock. “You’ve never heard of Mer-Mysteries?” She looks away and poses dramatically, “How could the Horde be so cruel not to provide such a basic human need?”

Catra’s not sure she’s ever heard a book series called a human basic need before, she’s had a lot of firsts today. “Well, we were the ‘evil’ Horde so nothing should be too surprising.”

“Monsters,” Mermista retorts, her face twisting a moment later when she realizes her insinuation, “I mean, most were monsters.”

Catra assures her with a short wave of her hand, “you’re fine, we really were monsters. I was one for sure.” Catra leans further over the side of this ship, holding out one hand to see if she can touch the water. Her fingers graze the surface and it’s cool to the touch. “People change though, that’s what I’m trying to do, I guess.”

Sea Hawk shouts awwww loudly, joining her at the side of the ship. Mermista doesn't join in his noise making, but she does smile at the comment. A moment later she leans against the ship wall as well, on the other side of Sea Hawk. "I'll lend you the first Mer-Mysteries book so you can see for yourself. They're about murder, drama, adventure, and sometimes a little bit of love." Mermista sighs happily, "They're great."

"I'll give it a try," Catra agrees. She's never been much of a reader but her newly developing friendship skills are telling her to do everything she can. Plus, she might actually like them, who knows? Maybe Adora will read them too and they can talk about them together.

Sea Hawk leaves them to tend to the sails for a moment, so Catra takes the opportunity to change topics. "I, uh… had an idea. About the boat burning issue." Catra motions with her ears towards where Sea Hawk is happily untying and tying new knots. "If you want."

"Oh really?" Mermista leans in closer to Catra. "I'm interested, please tell me more."

"Do you still have Horde ships around?" Catra clears her throat, "you know, from when we captured Salineas."

Mermista responds with an eye roll. "No need to remind me that you captured my kingdom while we were distracted back in Brightmoon. But yes, we do have some captured ships in one of our docks."

Catra steps back from the side of the ship and points along the floor with her foot, "If you take the liner from the inside of those ships, you can use it along the decks of these. The inside of Horde ships are completely fireproof, and one Horde ship can probably line five of these smaller ones." Catra faces Mermista who's expression has turned thoughtful. "Even if Sea Hawk felt like striking a match, it wouldn't do anything."

Mermista nods slowly to herself. “Yes, that could work. Catra, you, are, a, GENIUS.” Mermista pauses between each word for emphasis.

“Why is Catra a genius?” Sea Hawk asks curiously as he returns.

Mermista goes into detail explaining Catra’s idea for the ships. Sea Hawk laughs nervously, his face paling a little. “I don’t hate the idea, but what if I really want to light the boat on fire? Sometimes I just have to, you know how it is.”

“We don’t,” Mermista speaks for both of them. “I even tried it that one time, let me tell you it wasn’t worth it.”

Sea Hawk frowns, “It might be my fate then, to never again set a boat aflame.”

“That’s righ…” Mermista freezes mid word, head tilting, “Wait, did you just give up?” Mermista’s expression sinks into further confusion. “You never give up, this is very unlike you.”

Sea Hawk takes the opportunity to grab her hands with his, holding them firmly between them. “If it will make you happy, you know I’ll do anything. I admit I have some self-control issues around boats, but if Catra’s idea works I will never set a boat alight again, for you.” Sea Hawk draws Mermista’s right hand up and places a gentle kiss on the back of it.

Catra suddenly feels like an intruder on an intimate moment. She watches as Mermista’s face heats up red all the way to her ears, quickly looking down at the ship. “Well, maybe I can find you a super small boat every once in a while, so you don’t miss out.” She leans in for a kiss and Catra turns back towards the ocean to give them a bit more privacy. She follows the waves in the distance, only snapping out of it when she hears, “We’re being rude to our guest,” from Mermista.

Catra looks up, Sea Hawk is releasing Mermista’s hands with a laugh and goes to tend to the sails. Catra shakes her head left and right and raises her hands to mimic the motion, “Nah, you

guys are fine. Honestly, I'm used to this back in Brightmoon. Glimmer and Bow have been *all* over each other lately."

Mermista rejoins Catra at the side of the ship, "Oooh tell me more. I always knew they would get together."

Catra tells her about everything they've been up to since the defeat of Horde Prime, including dinner antics and the few times she's seen them making eye contact or touching when they think no one is watching. "They're cute together." Catra adds, "And uh, you guys are too."

Mermista thanks her with a light knock on the shoulder, then calls to Sea Hawk to start heading back to shore. They take the opportunity to show Catra a few knots, as well as how to lower and raise the sail.

It's a bit too much to remember, but Catra tries to follow along and soon they're back at the dock. Melog is waiting for them patiently, curled up in a cute ball. It unfurls and stretches as they tie the boat to the dock.

I lived!

Catra smiles, "Great job."

"Are you talking to me?" Sea Hawk asks as he knots the rope securing the boat in place. "If so, thank you! I did do a great job."

Mermista rolls her eyes as she steps out of the boat. "She was clearly talking to me."

Catra can't find it in herself to correct them. "I was actually talking to both of you." She gives them a toothy grin. "Thank you, seriously."

Mermista grins back, "Anytime Horde scum, but this party isn't over yet. You coming back to the castle for dinner?"

Catra finds herself surprised by their kindness for what must be the tenth time that day. She didn't expect to be invited back in for a meal, she was planning to camp outside the city with Melog and sleep in a tree. A warm meal and bed does sound much better. "That would be amazing." She agrees and Melog also grunts in agreement.

Sea Hawk steps between them, puppy dog eyes turned up to max. "What about me?" He asks in a pleading voice.

"Fiiiiine." Mermista tries to sound annoyed but Catra can identify the lightest of blushes on her cheeks, "You can come."

Sea Hawk shouts loudly for joy and runs down the dock, already hyping up the castle food and how excited he is to eat. Mermista exchanges an amused look with Catra before following. Catra takes a moment to scratch Melog behind the ears and thank it for waiting all afternoon.

After a few scratches, Melog stretches again and bounds after Mermista. Catra gives the boat one last glance before heading back towards the castle.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you to everyone who has read so far and kudos'd/commented!! I appreciate you guys so much.

Plumeria

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sea Hawk is right, the food made in the castle is delicious. Catra hasn't really found Etherian food that she dislikes, but the fresh seafood she eats that night is added to the top of her list of things to have again.

The beds are just as fluffy and absorbing as the ones back in Brightmoon, but Catra's exhausted so she quickly passes out, not waking until the sun peeks over the horizon the following morning.

Catra silently exits the room around 5:00 AM, being careful to tiptoe stealthily and not wake up Melog. She navigates the castle quietly, finding the exit and making her way to a familiar mountain side she sat on the last time she was in Salineas. The rocky cliffs remind her of when she found out Scorpia left the Horde, but also of the words they shared in Brightmoon, to find their own ways forward. She spends an hour sitting on the rocks peacefully, watching the ocean move beneath her feet as the wind rushes in her ears. A few seagulls fly beneath her and call to each other. Catra wonders what they're saying, she vaguely remembers Adora mentioning wanting to learn seagull, but she can't remember the details.

Catra returns to the castle after a short while to get her stuff ready. She wakes Melog and meets up with Mermista at the castle entrance.

Mermista has a paper bag and a small book in hand when Catra arrives. She hands her both with an insistent nod that Catra can't refuse. "These are leftovers from last night and this is the first book in the Mer-Mystery series." She also has two pears which she leans down to offer to Melog. "I'm sure you'll like the book. If you

don’t like it I don’t think I want to know.” Despite it probably being a joke, Mermista’s tone is dead serious.

“I’ll read it,” Catra promises, letting Melog eat one pear and then taking the other from Mermista. She places all of the food into her ruck sack to eat later while they’re traveling.

With that settled, it’s time to leave. Catra’s not good at goodbyes, her last few attempts have made that quite clear.

Mermista speaks, not seeming to feel the same nerves that Catra is, “So, have you fallen in love with sailing?” she asks with a slight laugh in her voice, like she already knows the answer.

Catra replies with equal merriment, “I don’t think so.” They laugh together for a moment. Catra pauses and waits for Mermista to finish laughing before continuing, her voice coming out softer as she changes the topic. “I’m sorry. For what I’ve done to Salineas, and to you.”

“We’re cool Horde scum.” Mermista doesn’t hesitate to respond, her smile not faltering in the slightest. “If your idea fixes my problem with my nightmarish boyfriend, I’ll owe you for eternity.”

Catra shakes her head, “We’ll be even. Seriously, you guys are pretty great.”

Mermista reaches out with her right hand, meeting Catra in the middle with a firm handshake, “You too, come back anytime.”

“I will, thank you.”

Finally, they part ways. Catra hops on Melog’s back so they can continue their journey and Mermista steps back towards Salineas, waving as they depart.

Catra has to pass Brightmoon to get to Plumeria, so it takes them about half a day to travel there. They stop for a break when they reach the river running through Etheria, enjoying the cool water and eating the leftovers that Mermista had packed for them.

They are pretty close to Brightmoon at this point and Catra briefly considers swinging into town to say hi to Adora. She selfishly wants to see her, but she still hasn't achieved what she set out to do and she doesn't have enough time to do so. Melog agrees with her that they should continue to Plumeria, there's plenty of time to spend in Brightmoon later.

They finish eating and cross the river on a fallen tree, continuing their trip north-west. They arrive at Plumeria in mid afternoon, probably between one and two if Catra had to guess. The sun is sitting high in the sky and it's a warmer day than the previous, Catra can feel sweat forming on the back of her neck and forehead as they arrive in town.

Catra hasn't been to Plumeria in a long time, but she does remember that they don't have a castle. Instead, she squints and peers around, looking for the tallest tree. That's most likely where Perfuma will be.

It's pretty easy to spot, standing at least 10 feet taller than the trees around it. Catra slides off Melog's back and enters the town, noting the stark contrast from Salineas and Brightmoon.

Instead of solid homes, everyone is bustling in and out of lightly colored tents, some of which are entangled with the trees and roots. It looks easier to set up and maintain for sure, though Catra wonders how cold they are at night.

A few villagers pause to watch her, she definitely stands out more here than she did in previous towns. The tall tree is just a few hundred yards away now, so Catra keeps moving without acknowledging the people staring at her.

She spots Perfuma in front of a tent a few feet further, still around the corner from the tree. Catra's glad she noticed her instead of going all the way to the tree and having to loop back.

Perfuma's currently reading a book out loud to a group of children sitting in a group in front of her, so Catra sits down near the back

to wait for her to finish. She hugs her knees to her chest, motioning with one finger for Melog to lie down by her side. Melog complies and Catra leans against its side and starts to listen to Perfuma speak.

"…and then the Princess shouted, 'I've always said the universe will repay the Horde one day. Well I guess that day is today!' and the entire village of Plumeria followed her loyally into the Horde base, pitchforks raised!" Perfuma flips the page of her book and holds it up, showing the audience two drawings. On the left is what appears to be a group of villagers holding sticks with spears and other swords. On the right is Horde members cowering in fear, hands on their heads. Catra squints, isn't that Scorpia's art style? It sure looks like her drawings, with bright crayon colors and carefully sketched lines.

Perfuma continues her story, "Once the group had overwhelmed the Horde, She-ra destroyed their base and healed the Heart Blossom. It is a day still famous across all of Etheria." Perfuma flips the page to reveal a drawing of what Catra assumes is the Heart Blossom. It looks like the tree in the center of the Kingdom she was originally heading towards, its leaves drawn in bright greens. "The people of Plumeria slept well that night, knowing they stood up for their Kingdom. The end."

Perfuma shuts the book as the children erupt in cheers. They start shouting, "one more time!" and, "what happens next??" Perfuma soothes them with soft tones, assuring them that there will be more story times later. As she talks to them she spots Catra near the back of the group, her face lighting up in the way that annoyed Catra back when they first met, but now she doesn't mind it as much.

Perfuma politely tells the children it's time to return home, which they do after a series of aww mans and bummers. Catra rises as they clear out, brushing the dust off her pants.

It only takes a moment for Perfuma to reach her, lips turned up in a bright smile and the book from before nestled in her left hand.

“Catra!! It’s so good to see you!” She stops a couple steps away, her arms starting to come up to her sides, “Are you a hugger?” she asks earnestly, motioning lightly with her arms.

This is definitely not what Catra was expecting to have to deal with, most people just hug her without even asking. She sees Perfuma’s hands moving towards her and instinctively leans away before even being touched. Perfuma is still about six inches from touching her and she curses her own reaction. The last thing she wants to do is come across as rude right now, but she couldn’t stop herself. “Uh…” Catra’s not sure what to say, but is spared when Perfuma drops her hands back to her sides, her smile faltering ever so slightly.

“Oh no, it’s okay!” Perfuma’s voice is still chipper and as she speaks her lips curl back into a full smile. “Not everyone is a hugger, I get that!” Perfuma holds up her right hand, “how about a high five? Huntara said these are all the rage in the Crimson Waste.”

Catra can’t help but smile at the kind words and gesture. She raises her right hand as well and gently taps it against Perfuma’s. “I hate to tell you, but I think Huntara might’ve been yanking your chain.”

“She would never do that!” Perfuma defends her, then pauses, her free hand moving to her chin thoughtfully, “Actually, it is possible.” Perfuma shrugs lightly, “even if that’s true, it’s still fun!”

Catra can’t argue with her positive spirit and concedes, her eyes landing on the book Perfuma is still holding tight. “Uh, this might be a weird thing to ask, but where did you get that?”

Perfuma glances down, moving the book to hold in both hands as she does so. “This? It’s a funny story actually.” Perfuma flips the book open to the first page, revealing a short message written in red crayon. “Scorpia made this for me. I was telling her the same story I was just sharing, and she said, ‘you know what would go great with that? Pictures!’ and she drew these for me.”

Old Catra would have felt bitter jealousy at her friend spending time with others, especially at her giving them drawings and growing closer with them, but she's pleasantly surprised to feel only happiness for them. She leans in closer to read the words Scorpia scribbled inside the front cover.

Never forget that you are brave! It's okay to rely on others, but don't be afraid to stand up for yourself and the people that you love. – Scorpia

Catra can practically hear Scorpia's voice in her head reading the message out loud. If Catra were emotional it might get to her, but she's not. She sniffles once and turns away, tail swishing. "It's nice." She clears her throat, "I mean, Scorpia did a good job."

Perfuma shuts the book and hugs it to her chest, a peaceful smile settling on her face. "She did great." Perfuma sighs happily, then perks up. "Well, let's get started then!"

For the second time on her journey, out of two she might add, Catra's not sure what they're doing. She holds off on asking for the moment, following when Perfuma motions for her to do so. Perfuma leads her towards the giant tree she was looking for earlier, which Catra now knows is called the Heart Blossom.

It only takes them about a minute to walk there, fortunately the people who were staring earlier have returned to their minding their own business or at least have the decency not to look. She's with the Princess anyway, so any suspicions of her have been alleviated.

There are a few blankets laid out in front of the Heart Blossom, mostly empty except for a small picnic basket sitting near the front of the center one. Perfuma sits down on the blanket with the basket, motioning for Catra and Melog to sit on the one to her right.

She slides the lid off the basket and starts to rummage. "I'm just so excited that you're here, did I already say that? Anyway, I

know you had a long journey, so I thought we would start with a refreshing honey melon drink. I picked this just this morning." As Perfuma continues to tell them all about the honey melon, she pulls a large yellow fruit from the basket. In Catra's opinion, it must be the only thing in there because it looks like it barely fit. The round fruit has a wavy pattern running around the outside and is at least as big as Melog's head.

Melog is interested as well, crawling into Catra's lap a little bit to crane its neck and sniff the fruit. *This isn't the kind I've been eating.*

Perfuma reaches into the basket and pulls out a small machete, slicing the top of the melon off with one clean motion. She moves the rind to the side, pulling out a bowl and two cups from the bottom of her basket. Catra wonders how those fit with the giant piece of fruit, but she holds the question for now and watches curiously as Perfuma pours a yellowish-green liquid from the fruit first into the bowl and then into the two cups.

"I hope you like this; honey melon is a particularly difficult fruit to grow. The vines are prickly and it needs extra sun and water." Perfuma places the now empty fruit shell back into the basket. She uses both hands to gently lift the bowl and place it in front of Melog before picking up the glasses and offering one to Catra. "Most of the time they don't make it, but if you treat them with enough love and care the juice is delicious."

Catra accepts the glass with a small thank you, angry with herself at feeling a little hesitant to try something new, but years of being on guard still spikes her instincts and she swirls the liquid in the cup to stall for a moment.

Melog shows no such hesitation and starts to lap at the drink, slowly at first but then quicker after it's had a taste. *This is good!* It purrs happily.

Perfuma takes a sip of hers as well, so Catra gives in and raises the glass to her lips. She can instantly tell why it's called a honey

melon. The juice is sweet, but not over the top. It's delicious and Catra tips the glass back to continue drinking it. She feels a flash of embarrassment for doubting her newest ally, especially over something so small. "It's good," she comments between gulps.

Perfuma is pleased, it seems she didn't notice Catra's earlier hesitation. "I'm glad you like it." She finishes what's in her glass and places it back into the picnic basket. Perfuma knits her hands together in front of her and bites down on her lower lip. When she speaks, her tone is much more serious, though she always keeps a hint of joy in it, "I've actually been thinking a lot about what we would do today." Perfuma frowns slightly. "If you aren't enjoying yourself, please just let me know."

Catra's heart falls a little at the comment, she wonders if she looks bored or annoyed. Maybe it's her eyebrows, Adora has always said her eyebrows naturally make her look annoyed sometimes. She tries to move them without being too weird. She takes one final sip from her cup, finishing off the honey melon juice. She passes the glass to Perfuma to put away and tries to think of a proper response. She doesn't want to upset the Princess, but it also seems like she might have subconsciously already done that.

"Everything's good so far." Catra responds carefully, "It's so relaxed here, much slower paced than I'm used to, but in a good way! It's nice."

Perfuma cheers up, her eyes gleaming in happiness, "Okay good! I'd like to try meditating together, if you are up for it. It's something I am passionate about and I think it might help you find internal peace."

Catra isn't surprised to hear it come up, as soon as Adora pointed to Plumeria on the map Catra figured there'd be meditation involved. "Sure, let's do it." She agrees.

If Perfuma is surprised at the easy acceptance, she doesn't show it. Instead, she moves the basket off the blankets so they can

spread out a little. Melog is just about finished with its juice, so she moves that as well so it can finish off to their left.

Perfuma shuffles to the center of her blanket and motions for Catra to do the same. "Okay, the first step is to cross your legs and place your hands on your knees. You can hold your hands in fists or palms, whichever is more comfortable for you. Personally, I prefer palms."

Catra mirrors Perfuma's posture, resting the back of her hands on her knees. It's not an uncomfortable position and the temperature is perfect since they're sitting in the shade of the Heart Blossom. Catra's not confident she'll be able to meditate to Perfuma's standards, but she's willing to try.

"Next, the goal is to empty your head of all thoughts. I like to focus on the breeze or the smell of the flowers around me." Perfuma holds her hands about an inch above her knees and closes her eyes, "Breathe in slowly through your mouth and out through your nose, pushing out all thoughts as you exhale. Let's do one together. Breathe in."

Catra inhales through her mouth, closing her eyes as well to try and get in the meditation zone. She holds her breathe for a moment, wondering how long Perfuma will make her wait.

"And breathe out." Perfuma finally says, both of them exhaling.

Catra tries to 'push all thoughts from her head' as they repeat the exercise, but finds her thoughts drifting to Adora. She's probably out in Etheria right now, fighting bots and kicking butt. She's so good at that. Her Adora, who works so hard day in and out, who put this trip together for her at the drop of a dime.

Shoot, she's supposed to be focusing on the breeze. Catra takes another deep breath, twitching her ears as she tries to focus on the wind. She can hear it faintly, but still can't keep her mind from going elsewhere. She wonders if Mermista tried the fireproofing boat idea yet.

Next to her, she can hear that Melog has stopped drinking. She opens her eyes briefly and verifies it's done with its juice. Melog has lied down between her and Perfuma, head resting on its paws. It's very cute and Catra fights the urge to reach out and pet it. She glances up at Perfuma, her eyes are still shut and seems focused on meditating, no longer directing them to breathe in and out.

Catra slides her eyes back shut and focuses on her posture, straightening her back and adjusting her hands. She's not sure how long they're going to meditate for but her impatience is already picking up, her tail starting to twitch. She forces it to stop, closing her palms into fists as she does so.

A stronger breeze picks up, and Catra once again turns her attention towards it. She tries her darndest to sit still, a bead of sweat forming on her forehead. After what feels like an excruciatingly long time, Perfuma finally breaks her silence. "Let's stop for now. Oh! Are you okay?"

Catra opens her eyes and realizes that Perfuma's looking at her with deep concern on her face. Catra glances down, noticing her own fists are clenched so tightly that her claws are digging into her palms. She relaxes her hands, wincing when her claws leave deep indents in her palms. At least she didn't draw blood. She brushes it off, wiping the sweat off her forehead with the back of one hand. "Yeah, I'm fine, sounds good." Catra leans forward, uncrossing her legs and drawing her knees up to her chest.

"That was a good session for me, I hope it was for you too." Perfuma stands up slowly, "Did you feel relaxed? I guess maybe not since your hands were clenched so tight."

Catra rises with her, nudging Melog with her foot as it had dozed off between them. She tries to answer the question honestly. "I think so? I could definitely hear the breeze. I was trying to sit straight was all." She holds up her palms to show Perfuma that there's no blood. "My hands are honestly fine."

Perfuma accepts her response. “Okay… It’s a good start then.” Perfuma pauses and glances up at the sun before continuing. “Now, I know you have a long journey to the Kingdom of Snow after this, so I don’t want to keep you too long. I want to show you one more thing if you have time.” Her final sentence comes out as more of a question than a statement.

Catra looks up at the sun as well, it’s moved a bit further down towards the horizon, but she probably has 4 hours until it’s dark. “Sure, I have time.” Melog rises as well and stretches, peering up at them curiously to see where they’re going next.

The pure joy on Perfuma’s face at her agreeing to stay longer brings a smile to Catra’s face, it feels good to be wanted and not just to be used. Perfuma leads them back through town to a large field surrounded by a fence. Various plants are growing in neat rows and a small wooden sign at the front reads “Perfuma.” Melog lies down in a patch of sun near the entrance, rolling onto its side and splaying out its paws. *This is the life.*

Catra hesitates near the entrance. “I, uh, don’t have the best track record with plants.”

Perfuma picks up a watering can near the entrance and pushes it into her hands with a small smile. “That’s silliness. All we need to do is water them and plant a few seeds. You can do this!”

She’s so convincing and kind, Catra finds herself nodding in agreement and stepping into the garden. The watering can weighs heavy in her hands, already full of water. She stops at the first row of plants. They’re a few inches tall, but she isn’t sure what vegetable they are. She tilts the can, sprinkling water evenly across them. After a few shakes she lifts the can to its original position and moves to the next row. Perfuma picks up a second can and starts at the back, moving with practiced ease.

Catra decides to strike up a conversation as she continues to water, “So… have you guys seen a lot of Horde Prime soldiers?”

Perfuma shakes her head left and right, “Fortunately no, we’ve hardly seen any since the final battle. Plumeria did have some rebuilding to do, but since most of our town is tents it wasn’t too difficult. My people have always been resilient.” Perfuma smiles, probably thinking about how proud she is of her citizens. “How about Brightmoon?”

“Not that I’ve seen.” Catra replies with a shrug, “but I’ve been staying inside the city for the most part. We did help with rebuilding homes, but thankfully that’s done now.” Catra wobbles on her feet as she nearly trips over a plant. “Sorry!”

“You’re fine! No harm no foul.” Perfuma excuses her with a polite wave. “That is good! Have you seen any other Princesses?”

Catra pauses, hands freezing just before tipping to water a plant. That’s kind of a weird question, isn’t it? Catra turns to fully face Perfuma, eyebrows rising slightly. “I saw Mermista yesterday, other than that no.”

Perfuma’s face has tinted red, though Catra’s not sure if she’s embarrassed or it’s from sun exposure. Both hands are on her watering can and she glances down at it, suddenly shy. “Have you seen Scorpia?”

Oh, so that’s what this is about. Catra turns back to the plants with a dismissive flick of her tail, she was worried for nothing. “Yeah, I did, she was trying out guard duty at the castle believe it or not.”

Perfuma turns back to the plants with a light chuckle gracing her lips, “that doesn’t really sound like something she’d enjoy.”

“Right?? I said the same thing.” Catra once again glances up, her lips curling up in a smile when she catches Perfuma’s eyes. “She said she’s trying to keep her options open.”

“That sounds like her.” Perfuma raises one hand to tuck a stray strand of her own hair behind her ear. “I hope she finds the right

path. I hope you both do." Her finger twirls the hair strand subconsciously, "I want to help too…"

When Catra responds, she tries to speak honestly, the way she's been trying to more recently. "You are helping. More than you know. For both me and Scorpia." Catra clears her throat. "Thank you."

"Awwwwww, that's what friends are for." Perfuma gives her a dazzling grin and Catra can't help but smile back.

The two of them work on the garden for about an hour longer, planting a few new vegetables once they're done watering. The sun is moving further down the sky, so Catra needs to hit the road if they're going to make it to the Kingdom of Snows the following morning.

Perfuma walks her to the entrance of the city, tears already prickling at the corners of her eyes. "Travel safe Catra," she says warmly through a sniffle.

"I will," Catra promises, reaching down to adjust the ruck sack on Melog's back. Once she's satisfied, she turns back to her newest friend. Yes, Perfuma is definitely a friend, Catra can say that with confidence.

Perfuma's slightly turned away from her, one hand loosely holding her other arm against her body.

Catra bites her lip, "Uh… one hug would be okay, I think."

Perfuma's posture instantly straightens, her eyes lighting up with joy. "Really??" She's already started stepping towards Catra without waiting for a response.

Catra laughs lightly, "Don't give me the option to change my mind." She opens her arms and Perfuma steps into them, wrapping her arms tightly around Catra's back.

It’s a different hug from the type Scorpia gives, super different. It’s different from Adora too, Perfuma is much softer. After a moment they part, and now Perfuma really is crying. She sniffles and wipes a tear away with the back of her hand. “Okay, you should go now, gosh this is embarrassing.”

“I won’t tell Netossa, she’d definitely use this against you.” Catra jokes, grinning when Perfuma laughs through her tears. “Take care.” Catra gives her a final nod and slips onto Melog’s back, taking off into the trees.

The sun will be up for a couple more hours, so Catra decides they should run for as long as they can and then make camp for the night.

After about an hour, Melog suddenly skids to a stop and jumps into a tree, nearly throwing Catra clean off its back.

“Hey!!” Catra starts to protest but is interrupted by Melog hissing *Shhhhh.*

It swishes its tail, pointing to a lanky figure moving through the trees between them.

Catra squints, the sun is partially down so it’s hard to see. They appear to be a young boy, tall and skinny with blonde hair. He has about ten sticks bundled in his arms. Wait…

Catra dismounts Melog and leaps out of the tree, landing in front of her target.

“Kyle?”

Chapter End Notes

This is the map I've been using for Etheria if you want to reference it: https://external-preview.redd.it/DE6XW123JVXaNtOjoj1SRz_IwhZ0tipcfeuTXBb3Hec.jpg?auto=webp&s=efe34ecc989dff7ce54b0a1efa52414a82f3e7ae

Old Friends

Deep down, Catra knew that her old training crew was somewhere on Etheria. She'd seen them last at the Fright Zone, but hadn't had any communication with them since returning to the planet. Personally, she was hoping they'd settle down somewhere far away and she'd never have to see them again. She buried down their entire existence, wiping it from her short term memory. It was like a bad dream.

Seeing them again is like flinging the lock on her repressed memories wide open.

All of the shame and guilt she felt comes rushing back as she stares incredulously at Kyle. He somehow looks the same, still dressed in the Horde's standard red and white outfit. He flinches visibly at her landing in front of him, lurching backwards and landing on his butt in the grass. The twigs in his arms fly everywhere as he raises his arms to protect his face. He holds the stance for a moment, frozen in fear. The only movement is his hands shaking as he holds them up between them.

Catra grimaces and crosses her arms, her left eyebrow curling up at his reaction. "Wow, you're as lame as ever."

Kyle lowers his arms slowly, still looking at her warily. He stands up carefully, brushing off his pants as he rises. "Well, you can hardly blame me." He bends down to re gather the sticks as he continues, "we weren't exactly on the best of terms."

Catra frowns at the comment, leaning down to pick up a stick that landed near her feet. She passes it to Kyle and glances up at the tree where Melog is still lurking, eyes locked on Kyle's blonde hair. "You can come down now, he's harmless." Melog grumbles and complies, so Catra turns her attention back to Kyle. "Where's the rest of your crew anyway?"

Kyle motions with a short stick over his right shoulder, "They're a bit behind me, I went ahead to gather fire wood so we can make camp." He picks up his final stick with a satisfied grunt. "There we go."

Melog has reached Catra's side now. It seems to have accepted that Kyle isn't a threat and walks up to him curiously. *Hello.* It grunts. *Fruit please.*

"Awww, you're so cute." Kyle leans slightly to coo at Melog. "I wish I could pet you, maybe later once I put down these sticks."

Maybe later, huh? Catra's not sure how much longer she can handle this awkward situation. She can't even imagine how much worse it would be if…

Her thought is cut off as the bushes behind Kyle rattle, revealing Lonnie and Rogelio a few seconds later. Lonnie is carrying a large backpack and Rogelio has a baby strapped to his chest. Of course, she summoned them by desperately wishing they wouldn't show up, that's just her luck.

They don't notice her right away, Rogelio is focused on the baby and Lonnie has her eyes locked on the ground, it appears they were following Kyle footprints. "Kyle! You've gone way off course. I told you to go north…" Her eyes flick up, widening when she finally notices that they aren't alone.

Several things happen simultaneously in the next few seconds. Lonnie draws a short club from her backpack. Melog leaps back to stand in front of Catra, hissing and changing its fur from blue to red instantly, hackles raised. The baby in Rogelio's pouch takes a quick glance around and tilts back its head, letting out a loud wail which gets louder with each passing moment.

Kyle tries to wave his arms and once again drops all of his sticks, "Wait, wait!! Everything is okay! She doesn't want to fight."

Rogelio hoists the baby up out of the pouch with a quiet grunt and starts to rock it slowly. The baby continues to cry but does

seem to quiet down ever so slightly.

Despite Kyle's words, Lonnie still looks like she wants to fight. "Nu-uh Kyle. Not after what she put us through. I need this." She slides her backpack off her shoulders and drops it to the ground with a loud thud, adjusting into a fighting stance.

Well, if that's what Lonnie wants, who's Catra to refuse her? She loosens her knees and starts to move back and forth between her feet, "As if you'll stand a chance." She taunts, hands coming up to form loose fists in front of her face.

"Guys, please." Kyle sounds desperate now, his shoulders slumped.

Catra slides to her left so she'll have a clear path to reach Lonnie. She gives her a quick once over. Lonnie honestly looks exactly the same as when she left the Horde, though her stance is a bit tighter.

Lonnie takes a step towards her, seemingly giving her the same analysis. The air between them is thick with tension and Lonnie gives her club a practice swing with a dark look in her eye.

Rogelio growls at them, the baby finally quieted down to little sniffles and the occasional hiccup. He grunts, shuffling to free an arm so he can wave it rapidly towards Lonnie.

Lonnie lets out a defeated sigh and relaxes her posture, releasing the club so it falls into the grass near her backpack. "Fine… For the baby."

Oh, so they're not fighting after all, that's fine too. Catra stretches to release the tension that was starting to form in her muscles and leans down to pet Melog, its fur changing back to blue when she makes contact. "What're you guys doing out here anyway?" She asks.

"As if you actually care." Lonnie spits darkly back at her, leaning down to pick up her club and backpack. She slides the club into a

pouch on the side where it must have been previously resting.

Catra's heart weighs heavy at the response, this group is not as forgiving as the Princesses, though it's more in line with what she deserves.

Rogelio has turned away at this point, probably to try and get the baby to stop hiccupping. Kyle is still standing in the center of the group, glancing back and forth as they stand their silently. He bites his lip. "H-hey, we were going to make camp soon anyway, why don't you spend the night with us?"

"Kyle!" Lonnie reacts harshly, walking over to grab him by the collar and tug him sharply towards her. "What do you think you're doing?"

Kyle yelps, "Hey! Look, she helped the Princesses, right?" He tries to step away from Lonnie, letting out a relieved sigh when she releases her grasp his shirt. "We should at least try."

Lonnie turns away with a huff, "Fine, but one wrong move and I'm taking action." She pulls a map out of her back pocket and unfolds it. "We're a little off course now, but we should only be an hour from Plumeria. This spot is fine for a camp I guess..." She folds the map up and tucks it back into her pocket.

"Great!" Kyle agrees a bit too fast and motions at the sticks on the ground around him. "I'll get the fire going!"

They never waited for an actual response from Catra, but she guesses it's settled for now. Lonnie once again removes her backpack, opening up the latch at the top and pulling out a rolled up tent. Rogelio sits down on the ground near Kyle, his attention still on the baby. The baby is happy again, gurgling and grabbing at Rogelio's finger as he moves it in a circle around its head.

They all seem to have a task; Catra feels out of place. She rubs the back of her neck with one hand, leaning back on the heels of her feet. "Uh… how about I get us some spare firewood?"

Kyle is already organizing his sticks in a neat pile and glances up from his work. “That sounds great!” He shoots her a thumbs up and a smile.

Okay, that’s something to do at least. She spins around and walks into the trees, this will be a good opportunity for her to gather her thoughts. Melog follows closely, glancing over its shoulder as they move away. *Is it really safe?*

Catra nods, pausing to pick up a stick as soon as they’re out of earshot. “Yeah, they’re harmless. I grew up with them in the Horde.”

Before Adora?

Catra blinks, hand pausing as it hovers over another stick. “I guess I haven’t told you about my whole past, huh? I knew Adora back then too, at the same time as them.” Catra picks up the stick and stands up, turning away from Melog as unwelcome feelings of pain bubble under the surface. She doesn’t like remembering that Adora left her in the Horde, and though she can accept she was being an idiot, it still hurts. “Adora left, and I guess they left too since they’re all the way out here.”

She’s not sure if Melog fully understands her explanation, but it can sense her jumbled emotions and drops the topic. It walks to a nearby tree and picks up a few medium sized sticks in its mouth.

Catra appreciates the silence as she continues to gather firewood. The last thing she expected on this trip was to run into Kyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio, though it was probably wishful thinking to believe she’d avoid them forever. She treated them unfairly in the Horde, barking out impossible orders and pushing them to their limits.

Of course, the first thing she did upon running into them today was be an ass to Kyle. Good going Catra. She bites her lip, eyes focused on the ground in front of her. She deserves their hatred,

and they probably won't forgive her. She should still apologize, it's part of her trying to be a better person.

Even if they never see each other again after this, that's fine. Catra nods to herself, her mind made up. She has enough spare firewood at this point and calls for Melog. The two turn around and head back.

It only takes them about a minute to return to camp. The tent is now pitched and the fire is crackling nearby. Rogelio is holding a bottle about a foot over the fire, presumably warming up its contents for the baby. Kyle is holding the baby in the meantime, snuggling it against his chest and talking to it quietly. Lonnie is sitting next to the fire, fishing through her bag for something. Catra's not sure what she's looking for, but she walks up wordlessly and places the sticks next to the fire. She sits down opposite of their group, Melog joining her there a heartbeat later.

Catra glances up, the sun is setting now, it'll be over the horizon in less than an hour. While she would have liked to travel a bit longer, this is fine too she'll just get up a little earlier tomorrow. She reaches over to her ruck sack on Melog's back and pulls out a few pieces of fruit and some rations that Adora had packed her.

She glances back at the trio. "Do you guys need food?" She doesn't mean the question to come out rude but realizes it may have been when Lonnie shoots her a dark look.

"We have plenty, thank you." The last two words are basically spat at her before Lonnie goes back to rummaging. Rogelio moves the bottle away from the fire, touching the outside with his fingers. After a second, he nods and grunts to himself. He turns and hands Kyle the bottle who promptly slides it into the baby's mouth.

Lonnie finally finishes searching her bag, coming up with a few cans of food. She opens them with practiced ease and passes them to her comrades. "See?"

Catra wants to respond, but she's not sure what she could say that wouldn't irritate Lonnie further.

Fortunately for her, Kyle cuts in. "So Catra! Are you traveling? Where are you going?" He seems to be asking from a place of honesty, and Catra appreciates him for changing the topic.

She passes a piece of fruit to Melog as she replies. "Yeah, I'm doing a bit of a road trip, I guess. I'm on my way to the Kingdom of Snows right now."

Rogelio lets out an impressed grunt while Lonnie scoffs. Kyle is also impressed. "That's so cool! We just came from there actually. It was cold."

This reminds Catra of her earlier question, well she didn't forget exactly it just got pushed to the side earlier. "Why were you all the way up there? Also… don't take this the wrong way but where'd you get the baby?"

Said baby is still drinking happily, totally unaware that it's their newest topic of conversation. Lonnie answers this time. "We found the baby in a village wreckage after leaving the Horde. We've been traveling all over Etheria to try and find its parents." She glances over at the baby, expression softening.

That's actually really nice, Catra can tell they've been taking great care of it. "Soo, what's its name?"

They all shrug. Kyle chimes in, "We made a group decision to not name him. Surely this little guy already has one, and we don't want to confuse him." His expression shifts into a slight frown. "At this rate we may want to, we've already been to multiple Kingdoms and haven't had any luck."

Lonnie shakes her head. "We talked about this Kyle, you can name him *if* we can't find his parents. We still haven't covered the eastern part of Etheria so we can't give up yet."

Rogelio grunts and roars a couple times, waving his arms around to express his opinion. Catra has no clue what he's saying but Lonnie nods as if he's agreeing with her.

"I know…" Kyle grumbles, adjusting the bottle to help the baby finish it off. "I'm just weighing our odds, you know? At some point we should find a more permanent living situation."

"We'll keep playing it by ear." Lonnie replies before emptying the rest of her canned food into her mouth. She chews and swallows before turning back towards Catra. "You look like you've been through a lot, I dig the new look."

Catra subconsciously brings one hand up to her hair, running her fingers through it. "Thanks." The trio is all looking at her now, this is as good of a chance as any to say her piece. "Actually… I need to get something off my chest." She takes a deep breath, "I was trash to you at the Horde, I'm sorry about that." She glances down at Melog who is watching her patiently. "I don't expect your forgiveness, but I wanted to tell you."

Kyle is the first to respond and he does so without hesitating. "Of course I forgive you!" He looks like he wants to run over and hug her, but the baby is still resting in his arms. Rogelio roars and shoots her a thumbs up, which she guesses means they are going to be okay.

Lonnie stares at her as if studying her, arms crossing in front of her chest. "Just like that huh, you're a changed person?"

"I'm learning and trying. From the Princesses and from Adora." Catra replies honestly, showing her emotions far more clearly than she ever has with her ex Horde mates.

Lonnie's arms fall to her sides and she leans back against the grass, her gaze still fierce. "I'm not as easy going as these two. If you ever make me go into an evil snow storm again, I'll kill you." Lonnie narrows her eyes and Catra can't tell if she's serious or joking.

She decides to go with joking and laughs lightly, happy to be correct when Lonnie cracks a grin and laughs as well. “No more evil snow storms, I promise.” She scratches Melog behind the ears as she continues. “I won’t give you orders anyway, we aren’t Horde soldiers anymore.”

“We’ll be okay then.” Lonnie leans in and holds her hands up to the fire. “You mentioned Adora, I heard the two of you are a thing now? You saved Etheria with a magic kiss or something?”

Catra’s face instantly heats up, is that really the rumor that’s spreading around about her? She supposes it’s about half true and better than rumors that she’s an ex Horde soldier. Still, she glances down towards the grass, trying to will the blush to fade from her face. When she looks back up, Lonnie is smirking at her knowingly. She finally replies, “Something like that.”

“Congrats Catra!” Kyle seems genuinely happy for her and smiles warmly. Rogelio grunts at her and nods firmly, which she once again hopes is a good thing.

Catra thanks them, and she really means it. Having their support even after everything, her chest warms as she’s overwhelmed with happiness. It really is unexpected, she can add it to the list of things that have surprised her on this trip.

Kyle finally removes the bottle from the baby’s mouth, its contents completely emptied. “Alrighty, I’m gonna burp him, then we should call it a night.”

Catra glances at the sky, the sun has set now but only barely and the sky is still partially light. “You guys go to bed this early?” She realizes after a moment that she’s once again being rude and scrambles to hastily follow up, “I mean, obviously you can do whatever you want.”

Kyle stands up, adjusting the baby so its head is resting over his shoulder, “Just for now,” he starts to pat the baby on the back

gently, “we are trying to get him on a normal sleeping schedule, and according to books babies are supposed to sleep early.”

Makes sense. Catra stands up as well, looking around to scope out a good tree to lie down in. It’s kind of early, but if she sleeps now she can get the head start she was thinking about no problem.

There aren’t any good ones nearby, she might have to walk for a bit to find one. She turns back to the group to wish them a good night, surprised when Rogelio and Kyle have already disappeared into the tent. Lonnie is standing at the entrance, watching her calmly.

Catra immediately feels defensive from catching her staring. “What is it?”

Lonnie raises one eyebrow at her and tilts her head, “You coming in, or what?”

Melog stays patiently by her side, but it looks up her curiously. *That would be better than a tree.*

Melog is right of course, but Catra is frozen from shock. Her heart swells from happiness as she mentally adds this to her ever growing list. She steps forward, walking around the fire pit to the tent. “Thanks.” She nods at Lonnie and steps past her, pulling the tent flap open to step inside.

Kingdom of Snows

Chapter Notes

> I'm really sorry that it's been 2 months. I've been busy but I'm back and I will try to be diligent and get this wrapped up. We have just 3 chapters left after this one!

Catra has a hard time falling asleep that night. She ends up reading the first few chapters of the book given to her by Mermista, the pages visible via a small slit of moonlight shining in through the front of the tent.

The book is admittedly better than she was expecting. The main character has an awfully familiar sass to her as she wanders into a rural town, quickly discovering that there was a murder the prior night. Catra reads until she reaches the scene of the crime and decides that's a good place to stop for now.

She tucks the book away and curls up under the blanket given to her by Kyle. Melog is curled up in a tight ball next to her, the two of them lying next to the tent's entrance. Catra pushes her face into Melog's side, the warmth of the fur reminding her just a little bit of laying with Adora.

She closes her eyes and drifts to sleep.

She's not sure how long she's been asleep before she's awoken by a wailing sound to her left. She presses her ears down flat against her head to try and muffle it, that baby sure has some lungs. Someone else is quickly on their feet to cradle the baby, making soft cooing sounds. Catra can make out the voice as Kyle's as he steps around her to carry the baby out of the tent.

It seems to still be the middle of the night, so Catra shuts her eyes and wills herself back to sleep.

She's woken up a handful more times by the baby, getting up herself when the sun pokes over the horizon. She pushes out of

the tent with Melog at her feet and sees Rogelio sitting on the ground next to the burnt-out fire. He's rocking the baby in his arms, nodding once at Catra to acknowledge her.

"Good morning," she mutters and raises her arms to stretch with a loud yawn. "He's like that every night?"

Rogelio once again nods, his expression seeming to look a little pained.

"He'll get better in time." Catra comments, reaching into her ruck sack to pull out some breakfast for herself and Melog. They have a long journey ahead of them and she'd be lying if she said she wasn't still exhausted from the broken-up sleep. She offers Melog a full ration and opens one for herself. She nibbles on it slowly, pausing to rub some sleep from her eyes with the back of one hand. Melog eats happily next to her and stretches out on the ground once it's done, its claws digging into the ground as it lets out a satisfied grunt.

We should get going.

Catra nods and finishes her food. She turns to Rogelio, "Hey, uh… will you say goodbye to them for me? I'm not running away or anything, we just have a long way to go." She glances down at her hands, why did she have to phrase that so awkwardly?

Rogelio grunts at her, which seems like an affirmative. It does dawn on Catra that Rogelio is not the best to relay a message. She glances around, is there anything she can write with? Her eyes land on the charred remains of the fire. That should work. She walks over to the fire pit and smooths the dark ash lying at the bottom so it's a flat layer. She grabs a nearby stick and scribbles as many letters as she can fit.

"GTG

THX 4 SLEEP

GL W/ BABY"

Her attention turns back towards Rogelio, “Just point at this, okay?”

Rogelio nods and everything seems to be settled. Catra wishes him luck and takes a moment to make sure everything she needs is in her ruck sack. The only thing missing is her Mer-mysteries book, so Catra ducks into the tent silently to grab it.

Both Kyle and Lonnie are passed out and Catra is careful not to wake them. Once she’s back outside she tucks the book away and slides onto Melog’s back so they can continue their journey.

Melog kicks off with its back legs and starts to run towards the Kingdom of Snows. They have to pass through the entire Fright Zone in order to reach it, which will take at least five hours. Catra’s not looking forward to it, but it was worth it to spend some time with the people she grew up with.

Catra zones out as they travel, not realizing they even left the Whispering Woods until the old Horde HQ appears on the horizon. She doesn’t spare it a glance as they ride past, the building holds many memories. Some good and some bad, but she made it through.

After a few minutes the building is far behind her, and Catra decides not to dwell on it. She allows her mind to wander once again until the snow starts to appear in piles around her, yellow scenery shifting to white.

A cold chill is also starting to creep up her arms and she shivers involuntarily. Maybe she should have packed a coat or something.

If Melog is cold it doesn’t show it, picking up the pace in excitement when it realizes they’re getting close. The temperature continues to drop as they run, and by time they reach the entrance to the Kingdom of Snows Catra’s teeth are chattering. She doesn’t remember it being like this when she came for Princess Prom. The excitement of messing with Adora must have

distracted her from the frigid wind, or maybe she's just misremembering. It doesn't really matter now.

They finish the ride in silence, the only noises being the crunching of snow beneath Melog's feet and Catra's teeth chattering against each other. She feels indescribable relief when the castle appears on the horizon. They'll have heat, or at least a jacket that she can borrow.

Two guards stand in front of the castle entrance, long spears in hand. These spears have large ice blades on the ends, and these come down to cross in front of the gate as Catra approaches. She grimaces as Melog skids to a stop in front of them, sliding the last few inches from the snow. It's the first time she hasn't been immediately welcomed somewhere, but honestly the hostility still feels a little more normal, even with all changes she's been going through. She slips off Melog's back and stands defensively, arms crossing in front of her, trying to stop her teeth from chattering as she speaks. "Princess Frosta should be expecting me."

The guards are wearing hats which cover the majority of their faces, but as they exchange a look Catra can tell they don't believe her. The guard on the right gives her a once over, stepping forward while keeping her weapon between them. A strong wind blows past, causing a shiver to wrack through Catra's whole body, her tail wrapping around her wrist to try and provide a little more warmth. Frustration from the cold and at the two stranger's incompetence claws at her chest. She inhales deeply, counts to 3, and exhales. "How about someone goes to check with the Princess?" She suggests it as calmly as she can, considering it feels like her feet are about to fall off her body.

"That's a good idea." The other guard chimes. "I'll go check." He lifts his weapon from the entrance and runs into the courtyard, leaving Catra with only one weapon pointed at her instead of two. It's a good start.

Not like there will be any fighting, because Catra has no intention of staying if she's not actually welcome. She shuffles towards

Melog, hoping to share some of its warmth as they wait. She rubs her arms and ducks down, her eyes shifting to the remaining guard. “Aren’t you cold?” she asks curiously.

The guard shakes her head no, “Our Kingdom supplies us with the best protective gear. It would take a lot more than this for me to feel a chill.” She smiles proudly.

That’s nice, Catra wonders how she can get her hands on some. She doesn’t have much time to think about it though, as she spots the second guard returning from the castle. He shouts as he gets closer, “Let her in!!”

Catra puts on her best lopsided grin, though she’s sure it’s ruined by her freezing body. “G-great, told you.”

The guard offers no apology, simply stepping to one side and lifting her spear to clear the path “Enjoy your stay.”

Catra leads Melog across the courtyard, heat washing over her when she steps inside the castle doors. She pauses there for a moment to warm up, brushing any loose snow off her arms and legs. After about 60 seconds she can move her fingers and toes again, so she presses on and enters the ballroom.

Well, it was a ballroom the last time she was here, now it’s just the main lobby for the castle. It looks very much the same, just without all the decorations. Catra’s eyes immediately land on the throne, but the seat is currently empty.

She glances around, eventually spotting the princess sitting at a large table to the left of the room. She has large books stacked in front of her, with one open in her lap. An older woman is sitting to her right, holding another copy of the same book.

Frosta is reading something out loud, it sounds like a math equation that Catra’s never heard before. The older woman sees Catra and taps Frosta on the shoulder, pointing in her direction to get Frosta to turn around.

The young princess swivels in her seat, her face turning bright pink when she realizes who's there. Catra's not sure why she's embarrassed, she seems to be studying, there's nothing wrong with that. She shrugs to herself, sometimes kids get worked up about the weirdest things, she was no exception.

Catra crosses the open space to stand near the table, Melog silently following her. "Hi Frosta," she greets her with a small wave. "Sorry if I'm interrupting. I can come back later if…"

"No!!!" Frosta interrupts her. "I mean uh, no… You don't need to come back later." She turns towards who Catra assumes to be her teacher. "Is it okay if we finish for today? We can spend extra time tomorrow if need be."

The teacher agrees with a small smile, giving Catra a warm look. She shuts the book and excuses herself, gathering up the remaining books and placing them on a shelf nearby.

Frosta clears her throat, pink still dusting her cheeks. "Right, follow me then," she demands, hopping off the chair and immediately turning to walk deeper into the castle. She walks fast, each step placed firmly and with purpose.

Frosta leads her to a side room, which appears to be a storage area/closet. She fishes through a pile of clothing in the corner, coming up with a puffy looking jacket and a pair of gloves after a few seconds. She turns and holds them out to Catra who gratefully accepts. "You'll need these, I can't believe you made it to the castle dressed like that." She motions widely to Catra's exposed hands, legs, and feet.

"Honestly, I can't believe it either." Catra slides the jacket over her shoulders, fumbling with the zipper for a moment before getting it to catch and sliding it shut. She slips the gloves onto each hand in turn. "Thank you."

"Of course," Frosta responds, then pauses. Her gaze has shifted past Catra, down past her feet. She can only be looking at Melog,

which Catra turns to confirm. Melog is sitting patiently in the doorway, ready to continue their adventure.

Catra senses someone nearing her from behind and steps to the side as Frosta suddenly passes her. Frosta is short enough that she doesn't have to kneel to be by Melog's head, and her hand is already extended towards it as she approaches. She suddenly pauses, turning her head towards Catra. "May I pet your cat please?" She's so polite, so different from the snobby child who scolded Adora at the princess prom. Catra can't help but be impressed.

"Melog's not a cat, but sure."

Frosta's lips curl up in a genuine grin and she leans in to pat Melog firmly on the head. "That's right, I think Adora told me about Melog. A space alien, that's so cool, even better than a cat! Yes, you are the coolest. It is you," she coos. Frosta raises her second hand to scratch Melog behind the ears, "So good."

She thanks Melog with another small smile and spins back to re-enter the room. "One moment please." She ducks past Catra again and returns to the clothing pile. This time it takes her a little longer, but she comes out triumphant with a long piece of cloth in her hands. She leans down, wrapping it loosely around Melog's neck. "To keep you warm."

Thank you. Melog licks her cheek. *I love it.*

Frosta giggles at the contact and finishes the final wrap of the scarf, tucking it into itself to keep it secure. "Okay, we're ready now."

Melog stands up and backs into the hallway, allowing Frosta to move past it and head back towards the castle entrance. The newly decked out travel crew follows her, Catra ready to face the cold with her new jacket.

She's not sure what they're going to be doing, but she doesn't get the chance to ask before Frosta's got them headed back into the

snow and wind, though she leads them to the right side of the courtyard where they're sheltered by a tall wall. Other than that, the space is empty. Well, except for snow of course.

Catra glances around, "uhh…" she hesitates, she doesn't want to offend her host.

Frosta's eyes rest on her for a moment, eyes widening when she realizes Catra's confused. "Oh!! I forgot the ice!" Her hands flair in front of her for a moment, then she draws them in and creates two blocks of ice. Each sit about 3 feet tall and a foot wide. "Sorry!"

Catra shakes her head and says that it's okay, the ice blocks sitting in front of them give her a pretty clear picture of what they're going to be doing. "Ice sculpting?"

"Yup!" Frosta puffs her chest proudly. "You're looking at the best of the best, and I'm gonna turn you into the second best of the best."

Catra smiles at the comment, deciding not to tell her that you can't have two bests of the best. "I'm counting on you then."

Frosta nods and taps her right hand against her chest twice, "Leave it to me, and if you don't like how they turn out, we can smash them." Even though it's probably a joke, Frosta sounds dead serious. She summons ice around her hands, her right hand in the form of a hammer and her left holding what looks like a pick. "So, the secret is really envisioning your final product."

Frosta steps up to the block of ice nearest to her and places the ice pick against the surface, hitting it softly but with precision and slowly moving in circles around the block. She inhales deeply, "Sometimes I forget to breath, so don't forget about that."

"Duly noted." Catra watches in amazement as Frosta continues to chip away at her piece, clearing out the top and then working on the middle. Catra can clearly make out the ears and head of Melog, perfectly proportioned to the real thing sitting by her side.

After a couple more circles, Frosta reaches the legs. “Now, when you get to bigger parts, you want to make big strong hits. She raises her right fist above her head to demonstrate and smashes it against her left. The ice falls away perfectly, leaving only the side of Melog’s ice leg. “Just like that.”

Catra nods as Frosta moves to repeat the motion on the other side. She steps back, grinning confidently, “Well, what do you think?”

The sculpture is a to scale replication of Melog, mane and tail included. “I’ve got to admit, I’m impressed.” Catra replies, and it’s the truth. She knew that Frosta liked to make sculptures, but to see her make one so precise in under five minutes, that’s true skill. This is the exact type of thing Catra wanted to experience on her road trip. She’s confident ice sculpting isn’t for her but maybe she can find something just like it, something only she can do.

For now, it seems like she’ll be giving this a try. Frosta creates two handheld versions of her tools out of ice, the hammer and the pick, and hands them to Catra. “Just make sure you envision the final result, that’s the most important part.”

Catra accepts the tools and steps up to her own ice block. She just stares at it for a moment, catching her own reflection against the smooth surface. She decides what she wants to make and places the pick carefully against the ice. Her right hand comes up and then brings the hammer down against the back of the pick, taking off a huge chunk of ice. Whoops, that’s not quite what she wanted.

Catra already kind of knew that she wasn’t going to be any good, but her competitive side still criticizes her for such a bad first attempt. She makes a few smaller chips, happy when she gets better results.

She picks away at the block for what feels like an eternity but was probably only ten minutes or so. Her hands are starting to freeze

from holding the ice, even while wearing gloves, so she steps back to look over her work.

Frosta places her hands on her hips and looks as well, her head tilting to the right ever so slightly. “Is it a person?”

“It’s Adora,” Catra confirms, “doesn’t look much like her though.”

“It does kind of suck,” Frosta speaks without thinking, quickly back tracking when she realizes what she’s said. “I mean, not suck… but… you’ve got room for improvement.” Frosta brings her hands together in front of her body and bounces on her toes. “If you wanted… I could help you, to make it look more like Adora.”

Despite trying to play it cool, it’s obvious Frosta really wants to help. This is a side of her that Catra’s never gotten to see, and she can’t help but smile at her eagerness. “That would be great.”

Frosta’s expression breaks out in a huge grin and she wastes no time getting to work. Within a few minutes the sculpture has been finished. Adora, albeit a smaller version of her, is standing proud with her sword in one hand resting at her side. She seems to be smiling, though Catra wonders if she’s drawing too many conclusions about an ice sculpture.

Frosta pushes the ice block so it’s touching the one of Melog. “All we’re missing is one of you now.” She comments, and though she probably made it innocently, the reminder that Catra has a caring family and life now fills her chest with more warmth than even the coat provided.

“Maybe next time.” She comments, eyes still locked fondly on the sculptures.

Frosta shrugs, “Ok, your choice. I’m gonna make us some hot cocoa, you want some?” She glances at Melog, “Can Melog have some?”

“I’d love some, and I don’t see why not for Melog.” Catra agrees and turns to pull her communication pad out of her ruck sack,

“I’ve got to make a call really quick, is it okay if I meet you two in there? If you ask real nice, I bet Melog will let you ride it.”

Frosta’s eyes light up in excitement and she practically leaps over to Melog. “Ooooh, is it okay?” She asks, once again her eagerness giving her away.

Melog grunts and stands up, turning so its back is available to Frosta.

She practically squeals as she climbs onto it’s back, and Catra can hear her asking Melog about their ‘team name’ as the two disappear around the corner.

Still smiling, Catra turns on her communication pad and is met with her contacts. She taps on the top person on the list, waiting patiently as it starts to ring.

“Hullo?” Adora’s face fills the screen, fortunately she seems to be resting at the palace.

“Hey Adora.” Catra greets her warmly, “I thought I’d check in.”

“Awwwwww, you missed me?” Adora teases her, but she’s also grinning from ear to ear. She never could hide her emotions.

Catra rolls her eyes, “Of course I did, silly…” if it weren’t freezing outside, she’d surely be blushing. She turns the camera towards the ice sculptures, “anyway, I wanted to show you these. With Frosta’s incredible teaching, I made them.”

Adora falls silent, so after a moment Catra turns the pad back around so she can see her. Adora is giving her a skeptical look, one eyebrow cutely raised. “Did you really make those?”

“Well Frosta helped, but yeah.” The two share a light laugh. “How’s everything back at Bright Moon?”

“Oh! It’s great!” Adora shifts, it seems like she sat down on a chair or bed. “I found a magic spring in the south, Glimmer and I are

going to head there tomorrow to see if it can enhance her magic. It was sooo cool, we can go too once you're back! How is your trip by the way?" Adora leans in closer on her side, which just makes her face fill more of the screen.

Catra can only grin at how adorable she is. "It's good, everyone has been extremely friendly, more so than I would be if I were them." She falls silent, a lump growing in her throat at her own comment. "Oh, I ran into Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. They adopted a baby."

"A baby?!" Adora exclaims, "No way!"

"I can't make this stuff up. The trip is going well though, I'm making the most of it, and I'll be home soon."

Adora nods, her expression suddenly serious. "Good, I'm glad. Mermista told me you're a life saver by the way, but I didn't get the chance to hear the whole story."

"I'll tell you in a few days." Catra promises. "Speaking of being home soon, my surprise is supposed to be in a couple days, can I find out what it is now?"

Adora shakes her head fervently, "Nope!!" She shakes it again for good measure, "Once you get to Erlandia, just give me a call. I'll give you further directions."

Catra gives Adora her best sad cat look, but she won't budge. "Fine… I'll wait." Catra glances up at the sun, noting it's moved towards the horizon. "I should probably go, Frosta is waiting for me."

"Okay, I won't keep you. Have fun!!" Adora blows her a kiss, then blushes deeply.

Catra raises one hand to mime catching the kiss, "Bye Adora." Her gut clenches at having to say goodbye, even though she knows it's not the last time they'll see each other. She clicks the

communication pad to off and turns to head inside, the hot chocolate is probably ready by now.

Dryl

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Even though Catra was just there with Adora, visiting Entrapta on her own makes her a bit nervous. Sure, everything was fine when they saw each other a few days ago, but Catra also knows that previous abuse can't be washed away with a few smiles.

For that very reason, Catra finds herself lingering in front of the Crypto Castle. Butterflies pull at her gut, dragging her progress to a halt. It would be so easy to turn away and move on, Entrapta probably wouldn't even notice.

Melog growls softly from its spot behind her knees.

You told Adora you would. It follows up with a soft huff, big eyes staring up at her.

Catra grimaces, her lips pressing into a flat line. She flicks her tail and rocks back on her heels. Melog is right, but she's not quite ready. Her gaze drifts up the castle, to the large satellite resting on its roof. Adora did a great job securing it, it hasn't moved even an inch.

"Alright… let's go." Catra concedes and uses all of her willpower to pick up one of her feet. She takes that first step and puts her hand on the doorknob. Knowing Entrapta, she probably left if unlocked. Sure enough, the door opens easily and Catra's met with a series of long winding corridors.

That's right, the Crypto Castle is a giant maze, how could she forget? Catra sighs and enters the door with Melog following close behind her. Of course she's never learned the layout of this place, she's really only been inside a couple times.

Catra should have called ahead and told Entrapta to meet her out front, but she didn't for the same reason that she was hesitating by the door.

The hallway has five or six additional paths branching from it and Catra lets out a frustrated sigh as she peers down the first one.

On the second thought, if they never find Entrapta then she'll at least have a valid reason to give Adora as to why they didn't meet. She shrugs nonchalantly and speaks, partly to Melog but mostly to herself, "This is a lost cause, we'll never find her."

Melog pushes past her, its ears up and pointed towards the left. *I hear voices this way.* It brushes its tail gently against her legs and points with its nose.

Melog clearly isn't going to let her off the hook and it leads them down the third hallway on the left. As they walk, Catra also starts to hear people talking. She can clearly identify Entrapta's excited voice, but there are a few male voices mixed in as well. Catra clenches her hands into fists and raises them to her chest as they get closer, could Entrapta be in trouble? Melog senses her trepidation and its fur bristles along its back, stepping gingerly to keep its footsteps silent.

Catra locates the room that the group must be inside; their voices are crystal clear now. Entrapta is clearly laughing at something, but Catra knows first hand that Entrapta can laugh and still be in mortal peril. Catra takes a deep breath and pushes the far side button to open the door, wincing when it screeches open. So much for subtlety. She makes sure to stayed tucked out of sight for the moment.

The male voices fall silent inside the room, but Entrapta continues laughing. Catra steadies herself and then peeks into the room, obviously her cover is blown but she doesn't want her head immediately blasted off.

She instantly realizes she was worried for nothing and all of the tension drains from her body. Entrapta is sitting at a large table, surrounded by little bits of metal and parts. Bow is sitting across the table from her, a large piece of technology in his hands. He looks like he was working on it a moment ago but is now staring towards the door. Hordak and Not Hordak are in the far corner of the room, and it appears that Not Hordak was mixing something in a big bowl, which he's still holding.

A chill shoots up Catra's spine at seeing Hordak. Talk about more bad memories, more bad things that she's done. He's also staring at her, his expression far calmer than she's ever seen on him in the past. He holds her gaze for a few seconds, neither of them wanting to look away.

Entrapta finally stops laughing and glances towards the door, drawing Catra's attention away from Hordak. "Oh, Catra!!! You're here, good!" She swivels towards Not Hordak. "Are those cupcakes ready yet?"

"Not yet!! We're getting close though!" Not Hordak resumes his stirring, "They'll be done in a jiffy!" He stirs faster as he talks.

Hordak turns to fiddle with the oven in the corner of the room, and Catra notices a baking tray on the stovetop. It has twelve slots in the tray for cupcakes.

Catra turns her attention back to the center of the room, where Bow is patiently waiting for his turn to speak. He's put down whatever he was working on and is slowly standing up. "Heyyy there most recent addition of the best friends squad." He walks over to the door in three quick steps, "It's time for your hello hug." He throws his arms around Catra before she can respond, squeezing her shoulders tightly. "This is from everyone."

Catra hesitates for only a moment before half returning the hug. Growing up she did have occasional contact with Adora, but hugs were not something typically exchanged in the Horde. She couldn't even think of someone who enjoyed them until she met

Scorpia and Perfuma. She can't say she likes them, but maybe one day. She releases Bow so he can return to the table. He gives Melog a hello pat as well as he goes.

"What're you doing here anyway?" Catra asks as she follows Bow to take a seat at the worktable. "Not like it isn't good to see you, I just wasn't expecting it."

Entrapta interrupts before he can answer, "We're updating the local communications frequency radio in order to increase its range. We're doing so by adding in additional converters, and I'm syncing them with the tower Adora placed. Speaking of which, once we finish I can show you." Entrapta motions towards Bow to resume his previous position.

Bow gives Catra a small smile and picks up the tech he was working on previously, holding it out a few inches above the table. Entrapta has a medium sized tool in her hands, though Catra isn't familiar with it. Both of them lower masks over their faces and get started. The end of the tool is pointy, and when Entrapta places it against the machine sparks fly between the two pieces of metal.

A spark flies particularly close to Catra and she hisses, which of course doesn't do anything. She ends up taking a step backwards to keep her distance and watches as Entrapta draws a line in metal across the surface of the tech. She draws a couple more lines, then turns off her tool. She flicks up her helmet, "This is so exciting! Let's test it."

Bow removes his face mask and flips over the machine, revealing a large screen on its face. He pauses to give Catra a little more information. "We're trying to build a communicator that can reach nearby planets. There are a ton of planets within a few days of flying time, if we could communicate with them we could establish trading groups and new alliances!"

That's actually really cool. She watches in awe as Bow turns on the device and the screen crackles to life.

A loud beep comes from the corner of the room, causing Catra to nearly jump out of her skin. Her head snaps around, and she sees that the oven is done pre-heating, so it was nothing. Hordak is holding a now full cupcake tray. He definitely noticed her jump but opts to say nothing and grabs the oven door. He slides the tray in wordlessly and sets a small timer sitting on the nearby table.

Bow's still clicking around on his screen, his lips turned down in a slight frown. "Dang, it's still not working."

Entrapta looms over his shoulder, a piece of her hair coming up to also prod at the device. She speaks into her small recording device that she always has. "Log 52, device is still not reaching required range, maybe we need another inverter?"

"Hmm." Bow raises one hand to his chin thoughtfully, "Maybe, but I'm honestly not sure. I might want to visit Mara's ship and check the technology on that, it worked so well maybe we can replicate it."

The two chatter back and forth for a bit, and Catra watches silently. She leans down to scratch Melog behind the ears.

"Oh, Catra…" Entrapta draws her attention back, "You're here to learn right? Welcome to science!! Isn't this exciting?"

Catra continues to pet Melog as she responds, "Uhh… no offense but I don't understand what you guys are doing at all."

Bow laughs, "if you end up wanting to pursue science there's a lot to learn. I think this is just about observing, right?" Catra nods so he continues, "if you have any questions while we're working don't hesitate to ask." Catra nods and agrees, and the two get back into it. They bring the pointy tool back out and fiddle away while Catra watches.

A few minutes go by, and suddenly Entrapta is looking up at her again. "I just had a great idea." Entrapta drops her tool onto the table and runs off towards a scrap pile to her left. She digs through the scraps earnestly. "A hah!" She exclaims and returns

triumphantly to the table. She has two small pieces of metal in her hands. “These will be perfect. Okay Catra, why don’t you try welding these together? Then you’ll understand.”

No way in hell is Catra going to approach the angry spark tool. She shakes her head and tries to think of a polite way to turn her down, “That’s okay. I… well, need to stay over here with Melog. Maybe next time.”

Entrapta blinks, then blinks again. She’s about to say something, but the ding of the oven timer cuts her off. She swivels around towards the oven, eyes lighting up in excitement. “Oh good the cupcakes are done.” She pulls a communicator out of her back pocket and calls for her staff to bring, “All of the tiny food in the whole castle,” and Hordak pulls the cupcakes out of the oven. They are steaming and the smell of cinnamon fills the air.

Entrapta haphazardly shoves all of the miscellaneous parts off the table with her hair, ushering Catra over to sit down. Catra hesitates, noticing that Hordak is paused by the oven, his eyes locked on her. He might not realize it, but he always stares when he wants something.

“I’ll be right back,” she promises and excuses herself from the table. Not Hordak is mixing up frosting by his side but is completely absorbed in his task. Catra crosses her arms as she reaches where Hordak is standing, “What is it?”

Hordak glances down at the tray in his hands. He balances the tray on one hand and plucks out the corner cupcake, holding it out towards Catra. “Sorry for trying to kill you.”

“It’s okay, I betrayed you like five times.” Catra reaches out to accept the cupcake, but recoils when she realizes it’s burning hot. “Uh, I’ll get one in a few.”

The two of them come to a silent agreement and walk over to the table to join the others. Catra takes the seat beside Bow. Not Hordak is close behind them, icing and a spatula in hand. Hordak

pulls each cupcake from its tray and places it onto the table, which Not Hordak then ices smoothly. “This is my favorite part!” Not Hordak says as he goes.

Melog glances up and sniffs the air. *Can I have one?*

Catra considers the question, they probably aren’t the best as far as health, but all Melog eats lately is fruit, this can’t be too bad for it. She takes one of the un-iced ones and places it on the ground. “Here you go. Be careful, it’s hot.”

Thank you! Melog takes a cautious sniff and licks it once, backing off for the moment when it confirms for itself that yes, the cupcake is very hot. Catra grabs an iced one from Not Hordak, which she also allows to cool for the moment.

The staff arrive a moment later, tiny food and beverages in hand. This further excites Entrapta, and soon Catra is enjoying a full-on buffet of tiny food.

Bow eats his fill as well and takes the opportunity to ask Catra about her trip. The two catch up, and Catra tells him about her sea adventure in Salineas and ice sculpting in the Kingdom of Snows. She leaves out running into her old teammates, but he’s pretty excited to hear about her adventures.

Once she’s done, she has some questions of her own, “So, once this device is done, what’s next for our great inventor?” She motions towards the communication device that they were fiddling with.

Bow’s delighted to talk about his work, “Well, since I’m our tech master and all, I’ll be flying out to the planets that we connect with. I’ll make friends with them and also learn about their technology.” Bow gazes wistfully at the communication pad, “I want to get started as soon as I can. I’m so excited to discover other planets. Growing up, my dads always talked about how the First Ones would describe the galaxies, but I never dreamed that

I'd have the chance to explore them myself." Bow motions across the table "Entrapta will come too when she can."

"Do you want to come with?" Entrapta cuts in, she's mid chew on some tiny food, but her gaze is piercing and stabs through Catra. Catra winces, even after so much time apart this girl can still see right through her.

Traveling to space does sound fun, but she could never leave Adora. She needs to find something on Etheria, even if it's not quite as exciting. "I uh, appreciate it, but I'll pass. I've had enough space for one lifetime."

Entrapta blinks, eyes still boring into her skull. A few seconds pass and she relents, "Alrighty then, your choice." Entrapta grabs a few more bites of food, dropping the matter completely. "That's Bow's goal, but my next project is much more exciting."

Entrapta points with her hair to the far side of the room, "I've been gathering parts to build a new portal device, but this one will be on a much smaller scale, and much more stable." Entrapta laughs, "Well I'm hoping it'll be more stable anyway. It'll be inner planet travel, and I think it'll work this time."

The thought of another portal makes Catra more nervous than she'd care to admit, but she simply nods and says it sounds interesting. She's sure everything will be fine.

That night, the group makes a small fire in front of Crypto Castle. It's Not Hordak's idea and it sounds fun, so Catra agrees.

Entrapta conveniently has random pieces of wood lying about so they quickly put the fire together and get it started. She also produces tiny marshmallows, which are about as difficult to toast as would be expected. They basically set on fire in twenty seconds, but this doesn't diminish Entrapta's enthusiasm for them. Melog curls up beside Catra by the fire, tail tucked over its front paws.

Entrapta is recounting her time on Beast Island, "… and then, I repaired the bot into near perfect condition. Bow was there he went for a ride with us. Wasn't she great?"

Bow confirms so Entrapta continues, "After that I mostly rode around and stole food from the King, though of course I didn't know who he was at the time. I was working on a few projects when you guys found me. We could have brought them if I'd had more time."

"It was for the best," Bow assures her, "We almost died like three times and we were only there for a few hours! Your robot beast wouldn't have fit on Darla."

"True," Entrapta shrugs, "I just wish I had all my research. It's okay though, it just means I get to recreate those things here."

That does seem like something Entrapta would enjoy. Catra appreciates hearing the stories, she's always felt bad about banishing her to Beast Island, so hearing that Entrapta at least got something out of it eases a tiny bit of that pain.

Bow sticks three mini marshmallows onto a stick and leans over to hold them over the fire. "You're headed back to Brightmoon soon, right?" His question is addressed towards Catra.

She nods, "Yup. I have one more stop in Erlandia, then I'll be going home." Catra leans over and waggles her eyebrows, "You don't uh… know something about my next stop, do you?"

Bow straightens his back and holds up his free hand between them. "Oh no, you aren't getting a peep out of me."

Catra leans in, her lips splitting into a mischievous grin. "Oh, really? So you do know?"

Bow pulls his marshmallows out of the fire, the top one is completely burnt to a crisp. "Nah-uh Catra, you'll just have to wait and see."

“Fiiine.” Catra grabs a marshmallow of her own and leans back, enjoying the fire and the company.

Chapter End Notes

I really like this chapter because the entire fic Catra has been apologizing to others, this is the first time someone else has apologized to her.

Erlandia

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra spends the night in Crypto Castle and heads out early the next morning. Erlandia is on the opposite end of Etheria, so it'll take most of the day for them to travel there. Bow's staying for another day at least, so they say their goodbyes.

The two of them travel in comfortable silence, with Catra holding onto Melog's fur as it carries her. They are passing by Plumeria just as the sun hits its highest spot in the sky, so Catra decides to stop in and surprise her friend for a quick lunch. Catra surprises herself a little bit with how quickly she decides to put herself back into Perfuma's presence.

Perfuma is overjoyed and drags Catra to a picnic by the holy tree. She also asks if Catra will participate in another meditation session with her, but this time Catra declines. She doesn't really want to travel in the dark, so she'll need to keep going to make it to Erlandia before sundown. Perfuma completely understands and wishes her safe travels, even going so far to wrap up a few sandwiches for them to enjoy as a snack later.

Catra departs with a thank you and the two continue their journey. They travel for at least a few hours without taking another break, only stopping when they find a small river that Melog cools off in. Catra pulls out the sandwiches as well and they share them before moving on.

When Catra reaches the border of Erlandia, the sun is about halfway down the sky, they made better time than she expected. Catra taps Melog and asks it to stop, pulling out her communication pad as it complies.

She presses a button to turn it on, then scrolls down to Adora's name. Her heart warms just thinking about seeing her and

hearing her voice. She used to always tease Adora for being a dork, but the tables have turned now. She's not as self-conscience as she one was, and confidently presses the button to call Adora.

Adora picks up after one ring, she must've been expecting Catra's call. When the camera flickers on, Catra's greeted with a close up of Adora's nose. While yes, Catra concedes it's a cute nose, she's can't help but wonder why she's getting such a close up. She'd like to see her girlfriend's whole face.

She hears Adora shout something muffled, which starts with "Glimmer," though Catra can't make out the rest. After a few more seconds Adora brings the tablet away from her face, finally showing herself properly to Catra. "Hey!!" She beams ear to ear, "Did you make it to Erlandia?"

Catra rolls her eyes to fake mock Adora's enthusiasm, "Yes yes, I'm here. So… what's this surprise? Do you need me to pick you some groceries or something?"

Adora ignores the sarcastic question, her eyes flicking past the tablet to where she was looking before. "Yeah, I'll tell her." Her eyes flick back down. "You're just in time, do you know where the Mushroom Amphitheater is?"

"Is it a theater shaped like a giant mushroom?" Catra arches her right eyebrow with a sarcastic smirk.

Adora nods earnestly, not picking up on her sass. "Yep, and it's close to the edge of town. Should be by the south entrance."

"Tell her to hurry!" Another voice, though muffled, comes through the communications pad. The pitch sounds like Glimmer, though Catra can't see her.

Catra smiles loosely at their antics, "Don't worry Sparkles, I'm sure I can find it." Catra thanks them and hangs up. She's only about ten minutes from the entrance of town and once she arrives, she's able to quickly find the theater. She's still not sure what they have planned for her, but clearly, it'll start with a show.

The Mushroom Amphitheater has definitely earned its name. A large mushroom operates as its roof, with rows of bleachers inside leading down to a large stage. The sides are open, making it an outdoor theater. Catra's surprised to find the seats nearly filled, with only a few open seats in the back. To be honest, given the size of the citizens of Erlandia, she'd sit in the back either way. She'd feel bad blocking the view for at least 4 of them if she sat in the middle. She picks a seat in the last row and sits down, her knees scrunching up a little bit to fit into the space. Melog lies down on the bench next to her, though it says it'll move if more mushroom people show up and need the space.

The stage has a very simple set up. There aren't any backdrops or scenery, just a door at center stage which is currently shut. It's brown with a brass handle and looks like it could be for any ordinary home. Catra glances around for some kind of hint as to what's being performed, but no one is holding fliers or anything which can help her. She leans her elbows against her knees with a sigh, she'll just need to be patient.

After a few minutes, the lights inside the theater dim, leaving only natural light shining in. A spotlight turns on from behind her, pointing straight at the door.

A second later an average height mushroom man waddles out from stage left. He's wearing a blue bowtie and black suit.

"How did it all go wrong?" He laments, bringing one arm up to cover his face dramatically. "My wife, my children, they hate me. And for what? This useless pride?" He rips off the bowtie, throwing it to the ground and raising his right foot as if he's going to stomp on it. He freezes, foot hovering above the tie. "No." He turns away, "I can't do it."

The man walks away from the bowtie and towards the door. "Is there anyone out there that can help me?" He steps behind the door, then opens it from the back. However, when the door opens the mushroom man is gone, replaced by a taller mushroom girl dressed as a fairy. She shuts the door firmly behind her.

Catra blinks, then blinks again. Was that a quick swap or is it? No, it can't be…

Catra watches as the fairy explains that she can take the man back in time if he will grant her one wish once everything is fixed. Then she disappears behind the door, with the man re-appearing when it swings open.

It is… Catra inhales deeply, that traitor, after all of that, settled down and is doing trivial plays? She exhales with a loud huff. Sure, she's been making friends with the princesses, but this is out of the question. How could Adora betray her like this.

Melog peers up at her from where it's lying, *are you okay?*

No, she's not. Heat pools in her gut and her shoulders tense, she has to get out of here. Grateful that she's in the back row, Catra stands up and exits the amphitheater, hearing the crowd break into cheers as she slips through the exit. Her heart pounds in her head with each step.

Her communication pad is in her hands before she even has time to think, practically smashing the redial button. The call rings a few extra times, but Adora does pick up. This time, she's already at an acceptable decision and still smiling happily. "Hey, are you having trouble fi…" Adora's eyes flick back and forth as she reads her expression, "What's wrong?"

"Double Trouble!?" Catra hisses, "What in Eternia made you think I'd want to see them?" It's a question, but Catra spits it so angrily that it comes out more as a statement. Her tail flicks angrily, ears flattening to her head. "Don't you remember what they did to me?"

Adora's lips have turned down into a small frown, "Of course I do." Adora hesitates like she's choosing her words carefully. "Double Trouble has changed. You of all Eternians should know that people can change." Adora takes a breath, "I thought, maybe, that the two of you could make up. Double Trouble has a lot of talent as

well, they can probably help you!" She glances down, "I'm sorry if it upset you."

Oh no, Adora looks like she's about to cry. Catra takes a deep breath, the heat draining from her head. "It's okay!" Catra tries to re-assure her and wills her ears to relax, fur on her arms still bristling. Adora makes a good point, Catra herself was in a similar position less than a year ago. Not to mention, Adora would never put her in a bad spot. "You're probably right, I should at least give them a chance." Catra grimaces. "One chance, if they blow it then I'm out."

Adora agrees and apologizes again, and the two finish the call on good terms. Catra hangs up and returns to the theater. She's missed a few minutes of the play, but she honestly doesn't care. The mushroom father is trying to get along with one of his children by making mushroom jokes, but none of them seem to be working. Eventually, the kid makes a pun back, and that finally gets them moving in the right direction.

Catra has to admit, Double Trouble is working their ass off and doing a great job. They play every single role in the play, changing characters by passing through the door in the center of the stage. At one point, they turn the door sideways and step back and forth, playing the husband and wife having an intense argument. It's fascinating to watch.

Before she realizes it, the play comes to an end. Surprisingly, there's no curtain call. Double Trouble doesn't come out for an applause, and within a few minutes the theater is almost completely emptied.

Catra takes the opportunity to walk down toward the stage, if Adora was involved surely Double Trouble knows she's here.

Sure enough, they appear at stage left about a minute later, already glancing around for her.

Catra slow claps, drawing their attention fully. “Encore!” She shouts mostly as a joke.

“Oh, you flatter me” Double Trouble brings one hand up to their chest. They step down off the stage with a flourish and meet Catra in the bleachers. “Welcome to the theater, dear. Was I a worthy surprise?”

“Not really,” Catra grumbles.

“Well, you’re stuck with me anyway.” Double Trouble turns away with a tut, “Now come, I have a wonderful meal planned for us.”

Catra follows with a deep eye roll, despite what Adora said Double Trouble seems very much the same to her. They lead her to a nearby restaurant, where they have a table reserved. It does seem fancy, and Catra will never say no to a good meal. The restaurant has a special table just for Double Trouble. It’s outside and is tall enough for them to sit comfortably. Catra’s begrudgingly grateful for the thoughtfulness.

They sit in silence for about a minute once they sit down, Catra opting to drink her water before she starts up. “So... What’ve you been up to since you betrayed me?”

Double Trouble visibly recoils. “Betrayed? I’m offended, you’re still caught up on that?”

“You nearly killed me.” Catra emphasizes each word, getting cut off by a mushroom person bringing them two plates of food. It looks like vegetables of some kind, sauteed. It smells delicious. Catra takes a few off the plate and blows on them for Melog, then places them down on the ground and starts eating herself. “So yeah,” she mumbles with food in her mouth, “I’m a little *caught up.*”

Double Trouble seems amused at her antics and starts eating as well. “You know how show business is, the curtains set on us. I suppose I did go a bit overboard.” Double Trouble pauses, then shrugs. “After that incident, I masqueraded as Peekablue for some

time. Unfortunately that plan… sunk.” Double Trouble takes a sip of water before continuing. “Literally. After that I ended up stumbling into Erlandia and decided to stay. I like the mushroom people, they get me.”

Double Trouble didn’t exactly apologize, but that’s probably as much as Catra’s going to get. She understands wanting to find somewhere to fit in all too well. “They don’t know it’s you doing the plays though, do they?” She leans back in her seat, “Don’t you miss the applause? I’m sure that must be hard for you.”

“It was hard at first,” Double Trouble concedes, “but I got used to it. I live for the stage, so I settled.” Double Trouble’s eyes suddenly light up, “Speaking of the stage, aren’t you wondering why you’re here?”

“I’ve been wondering that since I saw you step on stage.” Catra admits, “I’m kind of afraid to ask now that I know it’s you.”

If Double Trouble sensed her nerves, they ignore it. “I am doing another play tomorrow night, and I’d like you to help me with an opener.” Double Trouble fiddles under the table with a bag. They produce a few sheets of paper. “Here, take a look. It’s a skit for two people.”

Catra accepts it hesitatingly, her eyes flicking to read the front page. “A girl named Cindy and a wolf?”

Double Trouble nods, “An unlikely pair, you’ll play the girl naturally, and I’ll play the wolf.”

Catra cocks one eyebrow as she reads through the script “How much is Adora paying you to do this?”

“This is out of the goodness of my heart.” Double Trouble smiles warmly, and for once they seem to be telling the truth.

Maybe that’s why Catra agrees.

After sleeping on it, Catra considers leaving the following morning. She doesn’t owe Double Trouble, if anything Double Trouble owes her. Adora did set this up for her though, but what can she really get out of the experience? She’s not sure.

Yet, after eating breakfast she finds herself memorizing her lines. Double Trouble picked out a pretty good routine for them, though she’ll never admit that to them.

The next night, she meets them at the theater. Melog takes a seat in the front row and eagerly awaits the show. Double Trouble produces a pink dress for her to wear, which Catra immediately rejects.

Catra gets ready backstage, reviewing the lines one last time. They aren’t hard or complicated, she can do this. Double Trouble gives her an encouraging smile before transforming into a large man who has the face of a wolf. They give a practice snarl as the wolf, then signal for them to start.

Double Trouble enters the stage first with Catra following close on their heels, they’re supposed to be companions after all. She’s starting them off and opens her mouth to speak.

CINDY: I just assumed a witch put the Prince to sleep. They didn't?

WOLF: No, they didn't. That's a misconception.

The two of them cross the stage slowly from the left side to the right as they talk.

CINDY: A what?

WOLF: When someone thinks you're one way, but you're not.

CINDY: I know what that's like. Everyone think princesses are pretty and happy and fragile. But I'm not.

Catra pauses at this line, flexing for the audience.

WOLF: You are pretty, Cindy. Really.

CINDY: See. And you probably think I'm happy too, but I'm not. I'm downright depressed.

Catra lets out the saddest sigh she can muster and turns to walk away from Double Trouble.

WOLF: Need a scratch behind the ear?

Double Trouble reaches out to scratch her behind the ear, and Catra makes sure to thump her foot like she’s enjoying it.

CINDY: Hey, that does help.

WOLF: I have to admit, you do look a bit fragile though.

CINDY: See... everyone looks at me and sees a delicate flower, when in reality, I'm a deadly fighting machine ready to strike.

Double Trouble keels over, snickering loudly

WOLF: Really?

Catra smirks at what she knows is coming next. She steps in towards Double Trouble, stomping on their left foot with her own and grabbing their right arm. She twists away, throwing them halfway across the stage. She pretends to be shocked for a moment and runs over to their side.

CINDY: Are you okay?

WOLF: Mommy.

CINDY: I'm so sorry.

WOLF: No, I'm fine.

CINDY: You sure?

WOLF: Sure, sure. I just need a moment to get the feeling back in my body.

CINDY: I don't know my own strength.

Catra lets out a sigh of relief, she made it to the end. Double Trouble jumps to their feet and grabs Catra's hand, tugging her off stage. That's right, no curtain call.

The crowd cheers anyway as they exit. Warmth rushes to Catra's cheeks at the recognition. She peeks out to the audience and can see Melog beaming from the front row. Double Trouble starts getting ready for the main performance, so she sneaks down to the bleachers. She sits on the ground next to Melog, she doesn't want to block anyone's view. A mushroom girl sits on the bench

near her and tells her that she was great. She thanks them earnestly.

Double Trouble takes the stage as the mushroom man once again, repeating the play from the prior night. Catra pays closer attention this time, noting the intricate plot and how you can never ever see Double Trouble actually transforming on stage.

Catra waits after the play is finished, and once again Double Trouble meets her in the stands. “Did you love it?” They ask warmly.

“It wasn’t awful,” Catra concedes. “But I won’t be in anymore.”

Double Trouble winks, “That’s fine, darling. Theater will always find you.”

Not the best of interactions, but not the worst either. Catra wasn’t happy when she first arrived, but now she’s pretty sure she understands why Adora sent her here. Double Trouble is still the same mischievous actor that they have always been, but now they carry an air of maturity with them. They’ve found their path in life, something Catra craves for. Maybe, just maybe, she can do the same.

Chapter End Notes

Here's the link to the skit I borrowed if you're curious!!

https://freedramaplays.blogspot.com/2014/09/deadly-fighting-princess-short-scene_13.html

Maybe I won't take quite so long to write the final chapter.... can't believe this is ending soon.

Coming Full Circle

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Double Trouble offers to have Catra stay at their place for another night, winking and telling her she can stay for free. Catra's tired from memorizing the skit so she agrees with a sleepy nod. Melog curls up for another comfy night with little fuss, they don't want to make the run back to Bright Moon after dark. The inevitable ending of their trip is fast approaching, and anxiety gnaws at the back of Catra's mind as she lies down to rest.

She started this journey to find her purpose in Etheria, but after all these visits, she's still no closer to her goal. She turns restlessly, finally falling asleep for a few hours and waking as the sun peers over the horizon.

Melog is still curled up by her feet, snoring lightly with its tail resting over its nose. It lets out a quiet huff, bringing a small smile to Catra's lips. Melog's done so much for her, it's stayed by her side through thick and thin, a true friend. She's truly grateful that it accompanied her on this journey.

Catra pulls out the book Mermista gave her and continues reading, enjoying the quiet that she never got to experience prior to leaving the horde. Catra loses herself in the book, only noticing Melog's awake when it lets out a loud yawn and stretches, nuzzling its head gently to her leg.

Good morning it purrs. *Let's go home.*

Home… Has Catra ever thought about Bright Moon as her home? She can't remember, but the thought of having a place to return to warms her chest, pushing away some of the anxiety she was feeling the night prior. She closes her book and tucks it away. "I'm excited," she admits as she stands up and stretches her arms over

her head. She leans once in each direction, then leans down and picks up her bag.

To see Adora? Melog asks, accompanied with a tilt of its head.

Catra immediately blushes, her ears growing hot. She slides her pack across Melog's back, securing it under its belly. "Maybe."

Melog says nothing, just lets out a satisfied grunt.

Catra finds Double Trouble outside working on their garden, and she thanks them for the hospitality and begrudgingly says they can reach out to her the next time they're in Bright Moon.

With their goodbyes taken care of, Catra and Melog head out of Erlandia and back through the Whispering Woods. It only takes a few hours to reach the borders of Bright Moon, and Catra feels both relieved and nervous to return home.

She keeps an eye out for Adora as she rides through town but reaches the castle without finding her. She sets Melog up in the kitchen with a generous snack of fruit and makes her way to the war room. Outside of the guards it's been exceptionally quiet, maybe everyone is off on missions today?

Catra finally hits a strike, finding her favorite pink haired queen sitting at the war room table. She doesn't look like her usual sparkly self though, her hair is disheveled, probably because she keeps running her fingers through it. Strewn in front of her are folders and papers, some of which are up right, and some which appear to be upside down.

Catra clears her throat as she enters the room, trying to be polite but Glimmer still jumps at the sound. "Hey there, Sparkles, looks like you're having some trouble there."

Glimmer turns to face her, a clearly fake smile plastered on her face, "Catra! Welcome back!" The grin slides off her face and she collapses on the table, papers flying everywhere. "Ugh, I can't even fake it. I AM happy to see you, but this is a DISASTER!"

Catra moves to join her at the table, picking up the loose paper that fluttered to the ground. “Anything I can help with?” She sits down in the nearest chair to Glimmer, organizing the papers in her hands into at least a stack all facing the same direction.

“Do you know anything about logistics?” Glimmer peers hopefully up at her from the table, her cheek still smushing many of the papers.

Catra winces, remembering how she ran the Horde into the ground in a matter of mere months. “Uh… not exactly.”

Glimmer lets out a slow, drawn out sigh, “Then probably not…” She pulls her head off the table slowly, like it’s the most difficult thing she’s ever done. “Okay, get it together Glimmer, you can do this.” She’s clearly talking to herself now, but Catra watches as she pushes the papers she was resting her head on into a semblance of a pile.

Catra thinks she can at least try; she pauses for a moment and thinks of the best way to phrase the question.

She ends up being spared, as Glimmer turns to face her while she’s thinking. “I’m trying to balance Bright Moon’s resources. I want to build a school so we can teach trade skills, and I want to expand the city. We should have some excess resources somewhere, we have more than prior to Horde Prime’s invasion, but my mom didn’t teach me about any of this stuff.” Glimmer lets out another frustrated sigh. “Sorry, this *surely* isn’t what you came here for, how was your trip?” Her lips twitch into a half smile.

“It was great,” Catra comments, but her thoughts are still stuck with Glimmer’s current concerns. She leans in to take a closer look at the papers on the table, most of which are filled with charts of information and graphs to go with them. “You manage all of this?” Catra looks over, making eye contact with Glimmer, “That’s seriously impressive.”

A light blush splashes on Glimmer's cheeks, "Oh… thank you." Her voice is quiet, "I do have help, from the castle staff as well as Adora and Bow." Glimmer breaks their eye contact, eyes locking back on her papers. "Adora will be back later this afternoon by the way."

Catra's heart flutters at hearing her girlfriend's name, soon they'll be re-united.

A polite knock sounds behind them, and when Catra turns she sees another familiar face. Scorpia is standing there, rucksack in one claw and the other rubbing the back of her neck bashfully. "Hey there! Oh! I didn't mean to… Uh, do you have a sec? I've been looking for you." Scorpia's question is directed towards Catra. Something feels different from the last time they spoke. Scorpia is clearly nervous, but the air of uncertainty she carried with her before seems like it's dissipated. It makes a pool of nerves gather in Catra's gut.

Glimmer assures her that of course she's always welcome in the castle, and Catra rises and walks slowly over to the door. She exits wordlessly and heads towards the garden, Scorpia close behind her. She doesn't say anything as they walk, just thinking. Why is Scorpia here? Where is she going? These thoughts cloud her brain as she nearly passes the door to the garden, taking a step past it and then having to loop back.

Once outside, she turns to face Scorpia. "So, you're leaving?" She knits her eyebrows together and crosses her arms, even after everything, she still has a hard time with these types of conversations.

"Wow! Yeah, I am. I've always liked how perceptive you are." Scorpia speaks clearly, probably less nervous than Catra's ever seen her.

Catra's claws dig into her arms to keep her from wincing, "Where are you going?" Her thoughts drift to finding Scorpia's communicator in her room, realizing that she'd abandoned her.

She tries to push those thoughts away. This isn't the same, she reminds herself, not even close.

"Back to the Fright Zone." Scorpia responds calmly.

Well, at least that isn't too far away, but Catra raises an eyebrow, "Why? That place is a dump."

Scorpia smiles and looks out towards the garden, "I know that, but it's my home. I want to restore it to how it was before Hordak took over, re-establish the kingdom and all that." Scorpia extends one claw towards Catra, almost like she wants to shake hands. "I hope you'll come visit me."

Catra's chest swells as her pride for Scorpia's choice and sadness at her leaving collide. Tears form at the corner of her eyes, but she sniffs and forces them down. "Of course I will." She assures, opening her arms, "Now give me a hug."

Scorpia lights up instantly and wastes no time, scooping Catra up into one of her famous hugs. "Ooooh I'll miss you so much, please take care of yourself."

Catra wraps her arms tightly around Scorpia's back, nestling her cheek into Scorpia's warm but firm shoulder. "Yeah yeah…"

Scorpia puts her down after a moment, and Catra walks with her to the castle entrance, listening as Scorpia describes the remodeling that she wants to start with in the Fright Zone. When they reach the entrance she hesitates, turning back to face Catra. "Good luck with everything, Wildcat."

"Same to you."

Scorpia gives her one last smile and walks away, not looking back as she disappears down the steps away from the castle. Catra feels a swell of pride for her friend. Scorpia figured out what she wants to do and is willing to go the distance to achieve her goals. Catra knows she'll achieve them.

When Adora returns a few hours later, the first thing she does of course is throw herself onto Catra, knocking them both to the ground. The two giggle and burst out laughing when Melog squeezes between them a few moments later.

They join Glimmer for dinner, the Bright Moon paperwork all put away for the time being. As Catra eats with them, she can't believe she ever spent months away from Adora, she'll never make that mistake again. She fills them in on her trip, going through all of her stops and the antics she got up to. She leaves out the purpose of her trip, which only Adora knows. She's also not quite sure what to say on it, and there's nothing wrong with a little procrastination.

While they're eating, the communication pad hooked up to the war table rings. Glimmer answers thinking it might be an emergency, but it's just Perfuma asking for a favor. She says they have a few trees which need trimming, but they're very high up and her villagers are nervous. Her eyes light up when she notices Catra at the table, and she asks for her specifically, since she's so nimble and good at climbing. Catra's ears perk up at the request, being wanted for something other than war, it's a nice feeling. Her chest grows warm, and she barely registers the rest of the call, still in her own thoughts as Glimmer hangs up. She's not sure how the call ended either, so she'll have to remember to find out later if she's going to Plumeria. The interaction puts a tickle of a thought in the back of her mind. Isn't that task something Adora would normally do? Catra keeps mulling it over as she returns to eating.

Following dinner, Adora caresses Catra's hand with her own and leads her to the walkway leading to Bright Moon's orb. She releases Catra's hand to sit down when they arrive, leaning her back against the half-sized wall. Catra follows suit, re-linking their hands as she curls her knees up against her chest.

"I'm glad you're home," Adora practically whispers, leaning their shoulders together with the lightest of touches. "I missed you."

Her eyes are wide and earnest, and Catra leans her head down so their foreheads can gently touch.

"I missed you too." Catra inhales deeply and exhales, settling herself into the moment. She feels warm, loved, and safe.

They sit quietly for a long few minutes. Then, Adora pops her head up, a giant grin suddenly plastered on her face. "Sooooo," She pulls Catra's hand all the way into her lap, "Did you find your purpose for Etheria?"

Catra can't help but smile at her eagerness. She also thinks for a minute about the answer. Did she? She reflects on her journey. She went sailing with Mermista, gardening with Perfuma, ice sculpting with Frosta, tech tinkering with Entrapta, and acting with Double Trouble. She chooses her words carefully when she replies, "All of your friends are amazing."

Adora laughs, "They're your friends too now."

"You're right," Catra laughs, "I think the trip was just what I needed, and I do think I know what my path should be."

"Ooh oooh. Okay, I'm ready. Go ahead and tell me." Adora jiggles her legs a little in excitement.

"It's actually a bit of a combo," Catra admits, "Do you remember the mission I went on with you to Dryl? It was right before I left." Adora nods, so Catra continues, "That was probably something only She-ra can do, and I can admit that to myself. There are some things right now that you do for Etheria though that I can do." Catra motions towards the ground as she speaks, "Like the call we got during dinner, that's something I can do."

"I like where this is going." Adora encourages her with a gentle squeeze of the hand. "You want to work together?"

Catra shakes her head gently, "Not really together. I want to take some of the kingdom requests off your plate. Your focus should be on restoring magic to Etheria, not moving a pile of rocks or

trimming trees. Those are things that I can help with." Catra pauses, "So we kind of would be working together, just in different places and at different times." She leans harder into Adora's shoulder, addicted to the warmth she's getting from her. "What do you think?"

Adora doesn't hesitate in her response, "I think it's perfect." Adora lets go of Catra's hand so she can put her arm around her shoulder, pulling her in closer. "I'm proud of you Catra." Adora leans down and presses a gentle kiss to Catra's forehead, and the two stay like that as the sun sets in front of them.

The sun tucks itself beyond the horizon, saying goodbye to another day. Catra says goodbye to it as well, for once not fearing what will come tomorrow.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you to everyone for joining me on this journey! I truly enjoyed writing this fic I love Catra so much.

Please let me know how you liked it!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!